



PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

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Correction of errors of substance may be made only on the floor of the House with the permission of the Speaker. However, correction of typographical or grammatical errors which Members suggest for the Bound Volumes which will be compiled at the end of the Meeting may be clearly marked in the Daily Report, and the copy containing the corrections submitted at the Editor's Office, Parliament House, not later than four clear days after the publication of the Daily Report.

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

SECOND MEETING, 2025

Monday, 28th July, 2025

*The House met at the Chamber of
Parliament at 3.02 p.m.*

[MR FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER, MR
BERNARD AHIAFOR,
IN THE CHAIR]

ABSENCE OF THE SPEAKER

Clerk to Parliament (Mr Ebenezer Ahumah Djietror): Hon Members, in accordance with Standing Order 12(2), I wish to kindly inform you of the unavoidable absence of The Speaker, and to indicate that in his absence, the First Deputy Speaker will take the Chair and handle all matters relating to proceedings of the House until The Speaker resumes the Chair.

[PRAYERS]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us turn to page 2, the item numbered 6 on the Order Paper — *Correction of Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND
THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I have in my hand the *Votes and Proceedings* of Friday, 25th July, 2025, for correction.

Page 1...10—

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, on page 10 (c), the standard rendition for the Ministry should be Ministry for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts, and as it has been captured here, it needs to be corrected.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member you are right. Table, kindly take note.

Page 11...16 —

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I would like to take you to page 13 under the item numbered 14, Motion. I remember on that day the Motion that was moved by Hon Patrick Yaw Boamah was seconded by Hon John Darko and not Hon Kwabena Okyere Darko-Mensah.

So, Mr Speaker, the Table, should kindly check those again because consequentially, when you look at page 14, you would see that Hon Okyere Darko-Mensah seconding all the Motions ably moved by Hon Yaw Boamah, which rather was Hon John Darko, Member of Parliament for Suame. So, Table should kindly check for the correct Member who seconded from pages 13 and 14.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Table, kindly take note of the actual person who seconded these Motions.

Page 15...29.

Hon Members, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Friday, 25th July, 2025, as corrected is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we also have the *Official Report* of Friday, 18th July, 2025, for corrections.

Hon Members, the floor is now open for correction of the *Official Report*.

Yes, Hon Frank Afriyie?

3.12 p.m.

Mr Frank Afriyie: Thank you so much. Mr Speaker, these are just some minor yet significant corrections. The first one, column 12, line 6. I think the edition of the Business Statement on 25th July, as delivered by the Majority Leader, was supposed to be the ninth edition. So, in line 6, if the Office of Chamber Reporting could delete “8” and insert “9”. It was rather the ninth edition that ended on 25th July, which was last week, Friday, not the eighth edition.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very good. Office of Chamber Reporting, take note.

Mr Afriyie: Then again, Mr Speaker, column 41(w), I think the proper rendition of the institution is Architectural and Engineering Services Limited. Over here it is “Service”, so if we could delete the singular and insert the plural. Yet again, let me kindly walk you to (x). It is supposed to be “State Interests and Governance Authority”. So, could they add “s” to “Interest”. Then the last one, Mr Speaker, column 55(p). The “Annual Statement by the Audit Committee for the Akim North”. Per my checks, there is no municipality called “Akim North”. So, I

do not know if it is “Asante Akim North”. So, the Office of Chamber Reporting could take note and then do the proper insertion.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Hon Member.

Office of Chamber Reporting, take note of all the corrections proposed by the Member. Thank you very much, Hon Member, for those observations. Any other corrections?

Hon Members, in the absence of any other corrections, the *Official Report* of Friday, 18th July, 2025, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

I am to vary the order of Business for us to take the item numbered 8 at the Commencement of public Business, Presentation of Papers.

Yes, Second Deputy Majority Whip?

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

The Hon Minister for Transport is almost in the House. But since he is not with us, I plead with you to allow the Minister for Roads and Highways to lay the Papers on his behalf.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, the application to me is to allow the Minister for Roads and Highways to lay the Papers for the Minister for Transport.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: We do not have any difficulty if it is the Minister for Roads and Highways, except that he

cannot say the Minister for Transport is almost here. He knows it is not true. If he will make his application for the Minister for Roads and Highways to do it, let him do it. We are debating the Mid-Year Budget Review and his Ministers are not here, but he is rather making an application. He should look behind. Out of his 184 Members of Parliament (MP), they have about 15 sitting there.

So, Mr Speaker, we do not have a problem. The Minister for Roads and Highways can lay the Papers.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Thank you very much.

The item numbered 8(a). Hon Members, let us take the item numbered 8(a) (i), (ii) and (iii) together. Minister for Roads and Highways?

PAPERS

By the Minister for Roads and Highways on behalf of the Minister for Transport —

- (i) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the National Road Safety Authority for the year 2024.
- (ii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ghana Shippers' Authority for the year 2024.
- (iii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ghana Maritime Authority for the year 2024.

Referred to the Committee on Roads and Transportation.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, the item numbered 8(b). Hon Members, let us take all of them together.

Mr R. Acheampong: Mr Speaker, the Minister for Health is out of the jurisdiction, so I will plead with you to allow the Minister for Roads and Highways to lay the Papers on his behalf. Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister for Roads and Highways?

By the Minister for Roads and Highways on behalf of the Minister for Health —

- (i) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the College of Community Health Nursing, Winneba for the year 2024.
- (ii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Yilo Krobo Municipal Health Directorate for the year 2024.
- (iii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Yilo Krobo District Hospital for the year 2024.
- (iv) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Somanya Polyclinic for the year 2024.
- (v) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Health

Facilities Regulatory Authority for the year 2024.

(vi) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Medical and Dental Council for the year 2024.

(vii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the National Cardiothoracic Centre for the year 2024.

(viii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the College of Nursing and Midwifery, Nalerigu for the year 2024.

Referred to the Committee on Health.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: the item numbered 8(c).

Mr R. Acheampong: Mr Speaker, the Minister for Transport has just joined us, for the information of the House, because I told the House that he will soon be with us, and my Colleague was trying to say I was not telling the truth. Mr Speaker, since the Minister for Transport is with us, I will plead with you for him to lay the Paper on behalf of the Minister for the Interior. That is the item numbered 8(c).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Yes?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, we have no difficulty.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The item numbered 8(c), Minister for Transport?

By the Minister for Transport on behalf of the Minister for the Interior —

Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the National Identification Authority for the year 2024.

Referred to the Committee on Public Administration and State Interests.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The item numbered 8(d).

Mr R. Acheampong: Mr Speaker, going by the established protocol, I will plead with you to allow the Minister for Transport to lay the Paper for the Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources.

By the Minister for Transport on behalf of the Minister Works, Housing and Water Resources —

Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ministry of Works, Housing and Water Resources for the year 2024.

Referred to the Committee on Works and Housing.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The item numbered 8(e)?

Mr R. Acheampong: Mr Speaker, I will plead with you for the Minister for Transport to lay the last Paper.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister for Transport?

By the Minister for Transport on behalf of Minister of State in charge of Government Communications —

Annual Report on the Implementation of the Right to Information Act, 2019 (Act 989) for the year 2024.

Referred to the Committee on Information and Communications.

[Pause]

3.22 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the item numbered 8(f).

Hon Members, let us—

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I think if it is the item numbered 8(f), the Second Deputy Majority Whip, by Standing Order 217, can lay it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

By the Second Deputy Majority Whip on behalf of the Majority Leader —

Sixteenth Report of the Appointments Committee on His Excellency the President's nominations for appointment as Deputy Ministers.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, as agreed in the morning, we will go back to Statements.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Hon Members, we will go to the item numbered 7 – Statements. We have admitted a commemorative Statement, standing in the name of Hon Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin.

Hon Member, you have the floor.

STATEMENTS

World Hepatitis Day, 2025

Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin (NPP — Effutu): Mr Speaker, I thank you for this treasured space to make the Statement in accordance with the Rules of this House.

Mr Speaker, World Hepatitis Day is celebrated every year on 28th July, the birthday of Nobel Prize winner Baruch Samuel Blumberg, who uncovered the Hepatitis B virus and created the first vaccination.

Hepatitis B is the inflammation of the liver which is caused by a number of factors, including autoimmune conditions, alcohol abuse and viral infections. “Hepatitis: Let’s Break It Down” is the theme for the year 2025 and it is a call to seek urgent action in order to get rid of systemic financial and social barriers, including the stigma of Hepatitis which restricts access to prevention, testing and the treatment of Hepatitis B or C. It is estimated that 304 million people live with hepatitis around the world and, out of this number, 1.3 million people die each year due to liver cancer or cirrhosis.

Mr Speaker, hepatitis is a major public health threat in Ghana and,

approximately, 4 million Ghanaians live with hepatitis and are not even aware of it due to the lack of healthcare facilities, especially in rural areas. In some regions, the prevalence of Hepatitis C is much higher due to customs like sacrifices which may aid in the spread of the disease.

Initially, Mr Speaker, the viral hepatitis is usually silent. People may feel healthy while accidentally carrying and spreading the virus. They may only experience some symptoms like fatigue and jaundice after there has been a progression of the liver damage. Hepatitis B and C are the main causes of carcinoma in Ghana because chronic infection can result in a lifelong liver damage, cirrhosis and, ultimately, liver cancer.

People are discouraged from seeking testing or care because of stigma, false information and myth such as the belief that hepatitis is solely caused by alcohol consumption or contaminated food. This keeps the cycle of delayed diagnosis and conceived transmission going. Public ignorance, limited access to low-cost diagnosis and treatment and uneven quality healthcare across regions, particularly in impoverished regions of our country, have all contributed to the situation in Ghana.

Mr Speaker, from the theme of this year, “Hepatitis: Let’s Break It Down”, it is clear that we must confront this. We must break down the walls of ignorance, stigma, inaccessibility and, above all, costs which continue to deny many citizens the opportunity to access proper diagnosis, care and treatment. Health

equity, Mr Speaker, is not a luxury; it is a necessity.

The Effutu Experience: A Community that has moved into Action

Mr Speaker, in my own constituency, the realities of Hepatitis B are not distant. We have witnessed heartbreaking stories; mothers unable to afford immunoglobulin to protect their newborns and promising young people succumbing to liver failure, dying far too early. As a Member of Parliament (MP), I could not sit back and watch this trend continue.

In 2023, I commissioned a constituency-wide health survey on Hepatitis B, conducted in partnership with medical professionals. The findings were deeply alarming, revealing elevated prevalence rates, particularly among youth and pregnant women. It became clear to me that the cost of inaction was far too high. In response to this crisis, we launched the HepaGuard Project, which has now become institutionalised as the Afenyo-Markin Care Foundation—*[Hear! Hear!]*—I personally supported this initiative with an initial commitment of GH¢1 million to facilitate screening and vaccination of the people of Effutu through this project. Mr Speaker, this Afenyo-Markin Care started in 2023. Over 20,000 individuals have been screened and vaccinated in the Effutu Constituency. Hundreds of individuals have been initiated on treatment and dozens of newborns have received free Hepatitis B immunoglobulin to prevent mother-to-child transmission.

3.32 p.m.

Mr Speaker, to consolidate these efforts, construction is currently underway for a dedicated Hepatitis B and Liver Care Centre in Effutu: the first of its kind in the region. Furthermore, every 27th of May, which also marks my birthday, has been designated as Hepatitis B Awareness Day in Effutu.

Mr Speaker, while community efforts like these are commendable, they are not substitute for national policy action; more needs to be done.

The Broader National Picture

Hepatitis B continues to be a silent epidemic in Ghana. According to the World Health Organisation (WHO), 254 million people live with chronic Hepatitis B globally, claiming over 1.1 million lives in 2022, largely from liver cancer as already stated.

Sub-Saharan Africa carries a disproportionate burden. Over 91 million people in the region are infected and in 2019 alone, 125,000 deaths were recorded from Hepatitis B and C. Worse still, 90 per cent of those infected do not know their status and in every 30 seconds, someone dies from hepatitis-related complications. These are not just statistics; they are an urgent call to action.

Mr Speaker, here in Ghana, the statistics are no less sobering. According to the Ghana Health Service and WHO estimates, Ghana has an estimated prevalence rate of 12 per cent for

Hepatitis B, with even higher rates recorded in some rural districts.

It is further estimated that between 3 million and 4.6 million Ghanaians live with chronic Hepatitis B, often unaware of their status, as already stated so far. Worse still, up to 147 million newborns are exposed to the virus through mother-to-child transmission – the leading cause of intergenerational Hepatitis B spread in Ghana. Infected mothers with high viral loads have a 90 per cent chance of passing the virus to their babies, many of whom go on to develop chronic hepatitis, irreversible liver damage or liver cancer.

The burden, Mr Speaker, falls heaviest on the vulnerable: pregnant women in rural communities, babies born into poverty and families who are unable to afford viral load tests, liver function tests or lifesaving birth dose vaccines like Hepatitis B Immune Globulin (HBIG).

Today, many pregnant women are still not routinely tested for Hepatitis B. Those who test positive are not supported with antiviral treatment to suppress the virus and newborns cannot access HBIG or birth dose vaccines. These essential interventions remain unavailable or unaffordable, as they are not covered by the National Health Insurance Scheme (NHIS). This is an unacceptable gap and this, Mr Speaker, is what we must break down.

Yes, Ghana has made some important strides.

1. We have attained over 90 per cent infant immunisation coverage for Hepatitis B.
2. We have introduced free Hepatitis C treatment.
3. We have made antenatal Hepatitis B testing mandatory.
4. And we have developed a National Viral Hepatitis Control Programme (NVHCP) framework.

But frameworks and pilot interventions alone are not enough. Glaring gaps remain. As I speak, Ghana is yet to introduce the Hepatitis B birth dose vaccine or make Hepatitis B Immune Globulin (HBIG) freely available or subsidised. The result is that the poor are left behind and the virus continues its silent destruction. Too many Ghanaians are still dying from Hepatitis B, not because treatment does not exist, but because it remains financially out of reach. Mr Speaker, I dare say that the time for national action is now.

Mr Speaker, while community-based interventions are essential, they are not sustainable without national backing. The financial burden of Hepatitis B treatment remains a heavy load, particularly on low-income Ghanaians. Antiviral medication costs between GHC300 and GHC600 per month, with full treatment courses running into the thousands. Over time, this becomes an impossible burden for most households, so most patients go untreated, not by choice but by circumstance.

I reiterate a call I first made on this Floor in 2023: let us include Hepatitis B treatment under NHIS coverage. We have done it for certain chronic conditions. We can and must do it for Hepatitis B. Let us also:

1. Expand free community screening and antenatal testing.
2. Fund birth dose vaccine rollout and subsidise Hepatitis B Immune Globulin (HBIG).
3. Launch a national Hepatitis B awareness campaign to fight stigma and misinformation.
4. Equip every regional hospital with dedicated liver care services.

Conclusion: Let's Break it Down Together

Mr Speaker, the theme for this year, "Let's Break it Down" is both a bold invitation and a national mandate. Indeed,

- Let us break the cost barrier through comprehensive NHIS support.
- Let us break the stigma barrier through national education.
- Let us break the access barrier through targeted rural investments.
- Let us break the silence barrier through evidence-led budget-backed policy.

On this note, I call on this House, the Ministry of Health, the National Health Insurance Authority (NHIA) and all health-sector stakeholders to not just recognise this day, but to take historic steps toward transforming Hepatitis B care in Ghana.

Let us position Ghana as a leader on the African continent in the fight against viral hepatitis. Let us ensure that no child is born with this disease simply because their mother was poor and no adult dies silently for lack of affordable care. Let us break it down together and let us break it down for good.

Mr Speaker, on this note, I would like to thank you for admitting this Statement and to also thank Colleagues for indulging me. I am grateful and I hereby resume my seat.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much for making that important Statement.

Hon Members, I will open the floor for comments.

Yes, you have the floor.

Mr Anthony Mwinkaara Sumah (NDC — Nadowli/Kaleo): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the Statement ably made by the Hon Minority Leader.

I would like to commend the Minority Leader for bringing this important matter before the House and commend the interventions he is making in Effutu to deal with Hepatitis. Today marks the day

for Hepatitis and he has made very great interventions in his constituency.

We are learning from what he has done. Unfortunately, we are not as resourceful as he is, so that we can put such interventions in place. As I speak now, in the Nadowli/Kaleo Constituency today, we are doing screening for Hepatitis B and C. It happened last year and we covered six communities. Again, for the next three days: today, tomorrow and the day after, these interventions will take place together with the Liver Foundation.

The challenge is that while we pay some attention to some chronic conditions, the issue of hepatitis has been left to the backburner. To cite an example, we are particularly interested in preventing mothers who are HIV positive from transmitting the virus to their children under the prevention of mother-to-child transmission programme.

3.42 p.m.

Similarly, children can pick hepatitis from their parents, yet at delivery the same level of effort is not put in to prevent the mothers from transmitting it to their children. So, it becomes a chronic thing in a particular family that all the children coming out of the family will turn hepatitis positive.

Unfortunately, the interventions are quite expensive and left at the individual level, most people cannot. I think the call by the Minority Leader is something we should pay attention to. We should have some level of national attention on

hepatitis, particularly in the rural areas. Take my Constituency for example—Cultural practices, the way we treat corpse, share calabashes, communal eating *et cetera* makes the disease very prevalent. The results of the three days of test that was done in the Constituency was quite worrying and that is why this year again, we are in the Constituency doing same. A similar thing is happening in Daffiama-Bussie-Issa District and across the region, but we do not have a coordinated national effort.

I want to commend the Liver Foundation today because they have also put in some interventions in my Constituency to the extent of setting up a clinic that will be dedicated to dealing with hepatitis. But these are individual activities and interventions that are not coordinated and if you want to take the fight against hepatitis—Over 4.6 million Ghanaians have hepatitis. Had it been some other condition, probably it would have been making the news.

Secondly, recently when we were talking about chronic diseases and medical transplant, unfortunately they eluded all of us that hepatitis has chronic levels where treatment is expensive and should be considered under the scheme. Also, the National Health Insurance Scheme has not made provisions for such treatments. So, it is a clarion call and while I commend the Minority Leader for what he is doing so far, I think what he is doing should be rolled up at a national level so that people who have these conditions or are at risk of these conditions can get some help nationally to deal with the condition.

So, I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to this Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Hon Member. Yes, Hon Matthew Nyindam?

Mr Matthew Nyindam (NPP — Kpandai): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to also contribute to the Statement made by the Minority Leader. I thank him for making such a Statement and commend him for the amount of money he has spent on his Constituency to educate and treat Hepatitis B or C.

Mr Speaker, just like he said, GHC1 million—This is unfortunate. Most of us will not have that capacity to establish such a foundation in our constituencies. Mr Speaker, Hepatitis B, it is gradually becoming a household disease and we must all confront it head on. It is not out of place when he is calling on us to have a state policy on this particular chronic disease.

Mr Speaker, the consequences, are so huge. If we want to count the deaths, the total number of persons that this particular Hepatitis B or C has taken away, it will surprise you. I therefore want to add my voice and by the end of this Statement, get the Minister for Health to look at how best we can finance this particular disease.

Mr Speaker, the most important thing that the Statement highlighted has to do with the testing and the viral load. If you go to the hospitals and they want to charge you, you will not pay less than GHC2,000. Sometimes, when pregnant

mothers get to the hospitals and they are unfortunately diagnosed and they have to assist the unborn child, they pay not less than GH¢1,000. How many of our rural folks can afford it? Like my Colleague from the other Side said, if looking at the way it spreads and how we live in our communities, we virtually eat together, drink together, and even during our funerals, the way we adore and hold corpses, it makes it so easier for it to be transmitted.

Mr Speaker, I want you to take a very keen interest in this particular Statement and at the end of the day, let us have a way out, else one day, if you take 10 people, eight will be having hepatitis, which is avoidable.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to this particular Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you so much. Yes, Hon Joseph Kwame Kumah, you have the floor.

Mr Joseph Kwame Kumah (NDC — Kintampo North): Thank you Mr Speaker for the opportunity to have a bite on this Statement ably made by our Minority Leader.

Mr Speaker, I am scared for the broader national picture. I want to quote paragraph 9 and 10 to re-emphasise what has been indicated.

“Hepatitis B continues to be a silent epidemic in Ghana. According to the World Health Organisation, 254

million people live with chronic Hepatitis B globally...”

When we get to paragraph 10, it says that “...over 91 million people in the region are infected...” That is 2019 alone.

Mr Speaker, prevention we say is better than cure; the earlier, the better. We have nothing more to say than to quickly refer this issue to the Committee on Health for them to quickly let the Minister for Health let the public health authority engage in public advocacy so that we save our people. For lack of knowledge, our people perish. So, with speaker upon speaker buttressing these figures, should we wait for our people to finish?

A lot of our people in the rural areas are farmers. Mr Speaker, when we go on recess, we have to do thank you tours. When we get to some communities and the chop bar there has one cup for everybody to share and we are to share because you are with them. We are all involved, Mr Speaker. If we do not wake up to this call and treat this as a national security issue or a disaster, we are finishing. We are poor already and if the able-bodied people who are our farmers are to have this disease, then where are we? Our children are in schools, boarding houses. It is not easy. Mr Speaker, please, I plead with you, make an urgent referral of this issue so that we save ourselves.

Thank you very much for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you. Yes, Hon Member, you have the floor.

Mr Emmanuel Kofi Ntekuni (NDC — Pru West): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the Statement ably made by the Minority Leader.

Mr Speaker, this is a very important Statement that as a nation, we must take seriously. Looking at the socioeconomic impact of Hepatitis B on the individual, the society, and then the country as a whole, it calls for urgent attention.

Mr Speaker, as the maker of the Statement said, we have viral hepatitis and non-viral hepatitis.

3.52 p.m.

With the viral hepatitis, we have A, B, C, D and E, and the non-viral hepatitis; these are drug-induced, alcohol-induced hepatitis and autoimmune hepatitis.

Mr Speaker, the problem with hepatitis B and C, especially hepatitis B, is that it spreads faster than HIV. As we are talking about hepatitis B and C, it is important that we get to know the causes of these forms of hepatitis. It spreads basically just like HIV, through blood-borne activities like having unprotected sex, deep kisses with one partner having sores in his or her mouth, the sharing of items, especially the contaminated razors and brushes. These things are basically a problem in our rural settings, where affording some small amount to go and test to know one's status is a big problem.

Sometimes, through maternal care, they are able to detect it, but the money to buy the hepatitis B immunoglobulin to

prevent mother-to-child transmission is a big issue. Mr Speaker, I urge the Minister for Health to include the hepatitis B immunoglobulin in the NHIS so that when it is detected that they are positive during pregnancy, they can easily have access to it. This immunoglobulin is given right after birth. If a mother receives the immunoglobulin after 72 hours, it does not serve its purpose, because by that time, the virus might have crossed into the breast milk, and any child who takes or sucks the breast will get it.

I thank you for this very important opportunity. Yes, those who are infected have already said everything. The medical care is a problem. When one goes for medical care, they are asked to go and do the viral load. They cannot go, and sometimes, they go once because every year, one has to do it so that they will be able to quantify the amount of the virus in one's system and prescribe the antivirals. But the problem is the low settings. Are we able to afford these things? It is a big issue.

Mr Speaker, some of us have done the screening, and if you see the number of people who we did not even expect to have this kind of virus, it is so appalling. Just like the Minority Leader stated, I have made it a policy to also do the screening every year, so that those who will be detected will be managed. But another thing is vaccination. Getting access to the hepatitis B vaccination is another thing. It is costly, because one has to take it three times if one is not infected. But the people cannot afford these things.

Mr Speaker, seriously, we must include hepatitis B treatment and screening to the MahamaCare, to make it easy for the people to access. Thank you.

Prof Grace Ayensu-Danquah (NDC—Essikadu-Ketan): Thank you, Mr Speaker. I would like to thank the maker of this Statement. Hepatitis B is actually a very important public health concern in Ghana. Currently, we have about 4.6 million people in Ghana with hepatitis B, and that makes it 10.4 per cent of the population. It causes about 14,000 deaths every year, and hepatitis B and C are the ones that are infectious. They lead to liver diseases such as liver cirrhosis, where the liver is filled with fat and does not function, which eventually leads to liver cancer; it is the number one cause of liver cancer in Ghana.

Mr Speaker, hepatitis B is a sexually transmitted disease. Hepatitis B is spread by blood and bodily fluids. The solution to the hepatitis B problem is public health education. The people who are promiscuous need to be educated. Most people who have the chronic type of hepatitis, especially, do not even know they have it, and a lot of people, the prevalence and the incidence in Ghana are very high. But luckily, Mr Speaker, it was one of the problems that we had discussed in the NDC Manifesto, and the solution to the hepatitis B problem would be the free primary health care.

Currently, children are getting the hepatitis B vaccine in the pentavalent vaccines. So, they get it at six, 10 and 14 weeks. Currently, once the free primary health care programme is rolled out, we

will be giving the birth dose at the beginning of 2026. So, the NDC Government, under the visionary leadership of John Dramani Mahama — *[Hear! Hear!]* — is working on the problem. The problem has been identified. *[Uproar]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us have some order.

Prof Ayensu-Danquah: The problem has been identified. We are on course to bring the birth dose vaccine, which is for the children who are immediately born. The infants, the newborns, will be receiving a dose at the beginning of 2026. Once the free primary health care programme kicks in, we will do national surveillance. We will add the hepatitis B vaccine for adults. We will continue public education, and those who are found to have hepatitis B will be included in the free primary health care package.

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib (NPP—Weija-Gbawe): Mr Speaker, I thank you very much for this opportunity.

Mr Speaker, let me take this opportunity to also thank the maker of this Statement, Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin. This Statement comes at the right time. And for me, we need to consider what is more important at this stage, which is the preventive care. Growing up, I have always heard people say that prevention is always better than a cure. And that is why, for me, this Statement is profound. Mr Speaker, I would just make reference to the Effutu experience, where the maker of this Statement personally had to

support the initiative with an initial amount of GHC1 million.

Mr Speaker, obviously, most of us here may not have the resources to do that, but we should also be encouraged *ketewaa biara nsua* to wit, we can pay little by little and get to that level. Over 20,000 individuals have benefited from this screening through vaccination, especially in the Effutu Constituency. Where we have the maker of this Statement, who has also conceded to consolidate this effort by constructing a hepatitis and liver care centre in Effutu, Mr Speaker, for me, I think that this is worth commending.

4.02 p.m.

I am looking at the preventive side, which is, for me, abbreviated into SICI: Stigma, Inaccessibility, Cost and Ignorance. If we are looking at the stigma, what we need to do is to consider a more comprehensive education on hepatitis. I do not think that is just a matter of promiscuity; it also boils down to knowing what one has to do and not to do, including vaccination. If we are able to take this up and let people understand that the fact that one has hepatitis is not a reason for one not to seek proper cure and care, then we are moving somewhere.

Mr Speaker, the issue of inaccessibility; there are a lot of people out there who may never have heard of hepatitis. They do not know how to even reach out and how to get the necessary cure and vaccination, so if we are able to take this up, I am sure we can get somewhere. Then is the issue of cost;

what are we doing with the expenses involved? Are we in a position to get the submission made by the maker of this Statement that Government through the National Health Insurance Scheme (NHIS) should now respectfully consider taking the cost, bearing the cost for people who are unable to take care of this? If we are able to do so, a lot of Ghanaian lives, especially the babies, will be saved.

Mr Speaker, I think that there is the need for us to focus on what the current situation is. My Colleague just said we have about 4.6 million people who are suffering from hepatitis. How can we stop hepatitis? How can we break it down? Let us all come together, irrespective of where we stand or we sit, or whichever party colour we follow. Let us appreciate that hepatitis should be the thing of the past. Let us help in preventing hepatitis. Let us start now; we should start from our homes. We should start from educating our children; we should start with educating people who are nearer to us. Let them understand that hepatitis can also kill. It can affect our liver; it can take lives as much as possible.

Mr Speaker, with that, I am sure we can move forward as a nation and have a lesser number of people suffering from hepatitis and at most, have it removed from this society called Ghana.

Mr Speaker, thank you very much, for this opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you so much.

Hon Members, the Statement made by the Minority Leader is a very important one. I would therefore direct that the Statement be transmitted to the Minister for Health— But at Conclave we agreed it is going to be three comments from each Side. Is that not what we agreed upon?

Second Deputy Majority Whip (Mr Richard Acheampong): Including one each from the Leadership.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Including the Leadership here, it is three.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, can we have the last slot?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I am saying that including the Leadership here, it is three, but I have taken three here.

Hon Members, the Statement by the Minority Leader is a very important one. I would therefore direct that the Statement be transmitted to the Minister for Health for very urgent actions. In fact, the numbers are very scary. I also urge every Ghanaian to adopt very good health practices, so that we can avoid the complication from some of these diseases. So, the Clerks-at-the-Table, I accordingly direct you to transmit the Statement to the Minister for Health. His intervention is very important in this regard.

Hon Members, we also have two Statements. One standing in the name of Mr Akwasi Konadu, MP for Manhyia North to eulogise the legendary departed Ghanaian musician, Charles Kwadwo

Fosu, popularly known as Daddy Lumba. The same Statement is coming from Ms Adelaide Ntim, MP for Nsuta/Kwaman/Beposo, on the passing of the legendary musician, Charles Kwadwo Fosu. I urge the House to bear with me so that we can take the statement jointly. So, I will first give the floor to Mr Akwasi Konadu.

Tribute to Charles Kwadwo Fosu

Mr Akwasi Konadu (NPP — Manhyia North): Mr Speaker, I rise today with a heavy heart, yet a deep sense of reverence and pride, to pay tribute to one of Ghana's greatest musical legends, Charles Kwadwo Fosu, widely known as Daddy Lumba. His passing on the 26th July, 2025, at the Bank Hospital in Accra, after a short illness, marks the end of an era in Ghana's rich musical history. He was 60 years old and he hailed from Ekoo, Nsuta, in the Ashanti Region. Nonetheless, it is believed that he had lineage and could be traced to Parkoso, a town I come from.

Mr Speaker, unbeknownst to many, he was once rumoured to have aspirations to become the chief of Parkoso, highlighting his roots and potential influence in the community. Daddy Lumba was not just a musician, he was a maestro, an icon whose influence transcended generations and bodies. Widely regarded as the greatest musician of all time, his contribution to highlife music is unparalleled. Through a remarkable career, spanning over four decades, he produced 30 albums and composed more than 200 songs, many of which continue to enjoy airplay today.

His ability to touch on a wide array of themes, including love, heartbreak, forgiveness, wealth, death, betrayal, beauty and resilience, demonstrates the depth and breadth of his artistry. What made Daddy Lumba truly extraordinary, was his linguistic dexterity and poetic use of the Akan language, particularly Asante Twi. His lyrics were not only melodious and catchy, but often laden with proverbial wisdom, layered meanings, and cultural idioms that required deep thought to unpack.

Mr Speaker, for many of us, his music was more than entertainment; it was an education in values, life, and our Ghanaian identity. In an age where the vibrant tradition of highlife music had been gradually overshadowed by other genres, Daddy Lumba stood tall as a proud custodian of Ghana's musical heritage. He was a torchbearer and a trailblazer who constantly delivered timeless music, filled with thoughtful messages and profound advice.

Mr Speaker, his works were not just songs; they were experiences, carefully crafted pieces that touched hearts and stirred conscience. Take, for instance, the song "*Theresa*", for which part of it he says, "*se m'anyi w'aye a, enee na me nyiaye o, se m'amo wo din a...*"

Mr Speaker, this song emphasised the beauty and importance of gratitude, reminding us all to appreciate those who stand by us in difficult times. In "*Sika*", he says, *Sika na zye adee nyinaa*. He addresses the harsh reality of poverty and the need for us to eschew dishonest labour in favour of integrity and hard work. He

made a clear distinction between wealth acquired through genuine means and that earned through deceit.

Mr Speaker, in "*Adakatea*", he says, *obiaa nkwa gyina adakatea*—

4.12 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Akwasi Konadu, you should have done us the favour of translating whatever you have said in Twi into English language for the *Hansard*.

Mr Konadu: Mr Speaker, I will, and I will make that available to the Office of Chamber Reporting.

Mr Speaker, *Adaka tea* is a poignant reminder of the impermanence of life. He urged listeners to reject pride, selfishness, in favour of love and humility as death comes for all of us, regardless of our status.

Mr Speaker, it is not surprising that in the year 2024, H. E. Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo recognised Daddy Lumba with a prestigious national honour at the Accra International Conference Centre. In his heartfelt tribute, the former President aptly described him as "a pantheon among musical greats of all time". Indeed, the influence of Daddy Lumba extended beyond the boundaries of music. He was a cultural ambassador, a unifier and a beacon of creativity and wisdom.

Mr Speaker, the loss of Daddy Lumba is not just a blow to the music industry; it is a profound loss to Ghana's cultural

heritage and identity. His music brought people together across age groups, political divide, and ethnic lines. Whether at family gatherings, weddings, political events, national celebrations, his music played in the background, evoking nostalgic joy, reflection, and a deep sense of emotions. Through his art, he managed to build bridges and foster the sense of national pride. Many young musicians, today, cite Daddy Lumba as their greatest influence and inspiration. He opened doors for future generations of high-life artists, mentoring some directly and indirectly, and shaping the industry through the standards that he set.

His ability to reinvent himself while remaining true to his roots kept him relevant and beloved by the old and young fans. Mr Speaker, the void left by the departure of Daddy Lumba is vast and irreplaceable, yet his legacy endures, not just in the melodies we will continue to sing, but in the life lessons so powerfully shared through his music. He entertained, educated, inspired, and united us. That, Mr Speaker, is the mark of a true legend.

In this moment of mourning, I extend my condolences to his family, friends, the countless fans both in Ghana and across the globe. We mourn with him, but we also celebrate a life well lived; a life that brought joy, comfort, inspiration to many Ghanaians and citizens. May the soul of Charles Kwadwo Fosu, Daddy Lumba, rest in perfect peace. And may your songs continue to echo in our hearts, reminding us of who we are, where we come from, and what truly matters in life.

I thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you so much.

We then give the floor to Hon Adelaide Ntim; you have the floor.

The Passing of Daddy Lumba

Ms Adelaide Ntim (NPP — Nsuta/Kwaman Beposo): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to speak on the matter of deep national grief: the passing of one Ghanaian most iconic and influential musician, Charles Kwadwo Fosu, widely known as Daddy Lumba.

Mr Speaker, Daddy Lumba was born in Nsuta Ekuo in the Sekyere Central District, representing the Nsuta/Kwaman Beposo Constituency of the Ashanti Region. His musical journey began modestly starting with the participation in school and church choirs. It later took him to Germany, where he teamed up with Nana Acheampong to release the groundbreaking track, *Yee Ye Aka Akwantuom*, a song that launched a career lasting over three decades.

Mr Speaker, Daddy Lumba was more than a singer. He was a cultural icon and his music spanned generations, touching on themes of love, life, hardship, and celebration. He voiced the everyday experiences of Ghanaians, becoming a household name across the country and beyond. His contributions to the music industry of Ghana are invaluable. He was a pioneer of high-life and hip-life genres, mentoring many prominent artists. His sound evolved, yet his authenticity always remained intact.

Mr Speaker, on behalf of the bereaved and the people of Nsuta/ Kwaman Beposo Constituency, the entire Sekyere Central District, especially the paramount Chief of the Nsuta Traditional Area, Nana Asamoah Gyamfi Sekyere II, I call upon this House and the nation to mourn with us. Ghana has lost a legend, but his legacy endures. I humbly appeal to this honourable House and the Government to consider awarding national honours, including a state-assisted funeral and establishing initiatives to preserve and promote his musical legacy.

Mr Speaker, as we mourn, we also celebrate a life that touched millions. Let us remember Charles Kwadwo Fosu not just with tears, but with pride for the gift he was to our nation. May his soul rest in perfect peace. *Damirifa due*, Kwadwo.

I am grateful, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. I thank you. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

I will then open the floor to take comments on the Statements ably made.

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko (NPP — Effia): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the Statements ably made by my two Colleagues, eulogising Ghana's most influential musical legend in recent history, Charles Kwadwo Fosu, popularly known as Daddy Lumba.

Mr Speaker, the news of the sudden demise of Daddy Lumba came to many as

a surprise, taking into consideration the fact that, most recently, he celebrated his 60th birthday and very little would one have considered that he would pass on to the next world. As has been indicated by the makers of the Statement, the musical contribution of Daddy Lumba spanned about four decades, which means that Daddy Lumba launched himself into Ghana's music space at a very early age of about 20 years or thereabout. The music that Daddy Lumba produced or sang across these years portrayed him as one with a lot of depth in terms of wisdom, knowledge, and understanding in promoting Ghana's rich cultural history.

When we heard of the first song, *Yee Ye Aka Akwantuom*, with Nana Acheampong, those of us who were then in our primary school to secondary school days realised that this was a song that we could really relate to. But Mr Speaker, one song that I fondly remember Daddy Lumba of, and this House has to take particular notice of, is his song, *Ye Ne Wo Sere Kwa*. Mr Speaker, I do not know if you have heard it before.

[*The Hon Member sang Daddy Lumba's Ye Ne Wo Sre Kwa.*]

4.22 p.m.

Mr Speaker, to wit, the Majority is always laughing with the Minority, but we are unable to appreciate the love and the bond that we have to stay in this House together—[*Laughter*] With the demise of Daddy Lumba, I want to urge this House to remember him with this song that we have to unite as a House and

as a country. We should deal with ourselves in honesty and not in betrayal.

Mr Speaker, with that said, I want to pay a glowing tribute to Mr Charles Kwadwo Fosu for his contribution to music in this country and as has been proposed, I believe that the state ought to give him the needed honours and a befitting funeral, so that subsequent generations and the musical talents that are unfolding would also learn from the lessons that Daddy Lumba has given us.

Mr Speaker, with this, I want to thank the makers of the Statement for what they have done in remembering Charles Kwadwo Fosu, our darling Daddy Lumba.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further contribution? Yes, you have the floor.

Ms Theresa Lardi Awuni (NDC — Okaikwei North): Mr Speaker, I would like to commend the makers of the Statement in commemoration of the demise of the legend, Daddy Lumba. His music is not only played at parties or weddings, but it is a message to the entire nation: a message of hope and unity. One of his popular songs that is always played in my constituency, is *Theresa*—
[Laughter] Mr Speaker, his demise is a big blow to my constituency and I join the people of Okaikwei North to mourn with the family.

[The Hon Member sang Daddy Lumba's Theresa.]

Mr Speaker, I join the people of Okaikwei North and Ghana at large to mourn the demise of a legend. When one

attends any occasion in Okaikwei North, provided I am present, they welcome me with the song *Theresa*, be it at funerals or at outdoorings. This music has brought a lot of hope to so many Ghanaians.

I pray that like the Hon Member said, we should not just smile towards each other, but let us mean our words. Let us show each other love. When this Side brings Business to the House, genuinely join us to do it—[Laughter]

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.
[Hear! Hear!]

Mr Matthew Nyindam (NPP — Kpandai): Mr Speaker, today is a very sad day. A man I so love and cherish is no more. I extend my condolences to the family, the nation and the music industry.

Mr Speaker, Daddy Lumba never dies because in the music industry, the songs of Daddy Lumba will stay forever and ever. I am very sure and I will not be afraid to say that if we take the country as a whole, everyone will, at least, like one or two, of Daddy Lumba's music and I can see it from the faces of my Colleagues.

If you are sad, just play Daddy Lumba's music and you will be fine. If you are quarrelling with your wife, just play Daddy Lumba's music and you will be fine. Even if you want to do *galamsey*, play Daddy Lumba's music and you will be encouraged.

Mr Speaker, the man is a legend. If one has a problem with his wife, he

should just play, *Medo Wasem Bebree* and your wife is good to go.

[The Hon Member sang Daddy Lumba's Tokrom.]

Mr Speaker, this is for the *galamsey* people, so that they know where to harvest.

Mr Speaker, if one is a young man and they want to make it in life, they should listen to Daddy Lumba's music. If they play his music, they would be good to go. Although he is no more, let us learn through his music and try as much as possible, to pick from the words.

Just as others have said, we are in this House together; when we are laughing, let us express genuine love. Let us do it together. We should not pretend because we do not know when. It could be tomorrow or a day after.

Mr Speaker, I want to thank you and encourage you; I know you are a Daddy Lumba fan because by looking at your face, I can see one or two of his music on your face—*[Laughter]* When you get home, try and listen to one or two of his music and I am sure that you will be fine because *aye huhuuhu*. Sometimes, when you sit there, you can be—Mr Speaker, you understand what I mean. *[Laughter]*

On that note, I would like to thank you for the opportunity and, once again, I want to express my condolences to the family. Like one of the Statements said, we should treat him as a legend. As a nation, let us see how we can give him a

befitting burial. This is so important because people like Daddy Lumba, we cannot get much of them. Let us see how, as a state or a nation, we can eulogise our heroes.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, you have the floor.

Mr Ohene Kwame Frimpong (IND — Asante Akim North): Mr Speaker, I would like to stand on Order 63(1) of our Standing Orders and speak the Ghanaian language, Asante Twi.

[...Expunged by order of Mr Speaker.]

4.32 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, please let us go by the rules.

Dr Frimpong: Mr Speaker, I will be happy to translate the Twi into the English language after I have concluded. If you can indulge, please.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Dr Frimpong: Thank you. Mr Speaker, *Daddy Lumba aboa ama Ghana din apagya bebre. Ye hwe ne nnwomtoɔ, nkabom a ɔde aba ye fie mu, se ye wo onipa foforo,*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please limit it there and do the translation. *[Laughter]*

Dr Frimpong: Very well, Mr Speaker. To wit, Daddy Lumba is a great musician. He has sold Ghana across the borders of the world. As a musician from Ghana, I believe that Daddy Lumba has actually made Ghana a musical hub where a lot of Ghanaians connect. Mr Speaker, I will summarise it and say that Daddy Lumba is a great musician. He has connected Ghana to the world. So, I pray that the government of today helps the family to have a befitting burial for him and help musicians in Ghana to protect their intellectual property. Mr Speaker, I will end it here and I want to thank you for giving me the opportunity. Thank you very much. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, because we do not have the facility, everything that has been said in Twi but not translated into English is ordered to be expunged from the record.

Yes, Hon Member for Bosome Freho, you have the floor.

Nana Asafo-Agyei Ayeh (NPP—Bosome Freho): Thank you. Mr Speaker, I would want to join the Member of Parliament (MP) from Daddy Lumba's home constituency, Hon Adelaide Ntim, and the MP from Manhyia North, for the Statement they have made today on the Floor. Mr Speaker, it is with a great heart and deep sorrow that I want to join the teeming Ghanaians who are today mourning the passage of the legend, the icon, the star of Ghana, Charles Kwadwo Fosu, a.k.a. Daddy Lumba. Mr Speaker, in fact, I am one of the members of the fan club of Daddy Lumba, and my favourite song of all time, Mr Speaker, if you

permit me, I would want to take a few lines.

[The Hon Member sang a portion of Daddy Lumba's Sɛ Wotan me a.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: To wit?

Nana Ayeh: Mr Speaker, to wit, if I have not done any wrong to you, I have not offended you in any way, I have not wronged you, and you hate me, then you are lying. Mr Speaker, the track goes on to even say how he is fortified in the word of God.

Mr Speaker, this is the man we are celebrating today. As a young party boy, a New Patriotic Party (NPP) young man who was fan of the party, Mr Speaker, one of his major campaign songs

[The Hon Member sang a portion of Daddy Lumba's Nana Winner.]

Mr Speaker, where one would even enjoy that one most is where he goes *Hey na ɔsono eh, Hey na ɔsono eh, kukrudu NPP*. This is the man Ghana is mourning today; it is very sad.

Mr Speaker, we have a number of stars that are no longer with us today. Quite recently, KKD also passed on—Dada KD, Nana Kwakye Duah yes. Mr Speaker, I said KKD, forgive me, it is Dada KD. Mr Speaker, I think that the family of Daddy Lumba should allow the state to give him a befitting state burial, because he has outlived the confines of his family. He is a national asset. Mr Speaker, I would crave their indulgence if they are listening to us. They should allow

the state give him a befitting barrier, because he has sold, marketed, and projected Ghana through his music to the international world.

Mr Speaker, finally I would want to beg that the nation should have a high-life museum where we have all art and works of our high-life musicians displayed there. This is because, in Ghana, one of the major music genres is high-life. Mr Speaker, we do not even have anything in this country that depicts the fact that that is our music genre. We should use the passing of Lumba to make sure that we set up a music genre, high-life studios or high-life museum so that Ghana and everybody who comes to Ghana can have a share of that.

Mr Speaker, to conclude, I want to take the lines again —

[The Hon Member sang Daddy Lumba's Se Wo Tan Mea]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, no singing. Conclude.

Nana Ayeh: I am concluding.
[The Hon Member sang]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Can you resume your seats? Yes, Leadership.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I would yield to Hon Nitiwul.

Mr Dominic Bingab Aduna Nitiwul (NPP—Bimbilla): Mr Speaker, I want to thank you very much. When news broke that we had indeed lost Daddy Lumba, I am almost certain that there are many

people in this Chamber who shed tears, including myself. Even those who do not speak impeccable Twi or do not even speak the Twi language, whenever they played Daddy Lumba's song, they enjoy it. Mr Speaker, even those whose mother tongue is not the Twi language, any time Daddy Lumba's song was played, they enjoyed it. Mr Speaker, Daddy Lumba is "our Michael Jackson".

This is a man whose music cuts across all ages; from the young to the middle-aged to the old. And how he did it is still a marvel to some of us, that every year, since 1989 when he started with Nana Acheampong, he always came with a hit. There was no year that people were not waiting for Daddy Lumba to bring a song in December. Every year, Daddy Lumba always brought a hit song or a couple of hit songs in December. He entertained Ghanaians for more than 30 or 40 years. We should celebrate him.

4.42 p.m.

The nation owes it a duty to celebrate Daddy Lumba. Mr Speaker, Lumba has left a mark, and I believe for many years to come, he may end up like Bob Marley, where even when he is not there, Ghanaians will still be playing his music. He was one of the few who held the highlife music through the skies. Ghanaians were known for highlife music. Today, it is changing. Many people and countries copied highlife music and Daddy Lumba represented the best of Highlife music.

Mr Speaker, if you ask those who speak and understand Twi language well,

they will tell you how he composes his music, the lyrics, and the thought behind it marvels everybody. I remember somebody asked him what the meaning of *aben wo ha* is. They asked him, what is that? What were you talking about? Mr Speaker, what the average Ghanaian thought he was going to say, he never said that. That is the type of person we are mourning today.

It is unfortunate we have lost him at a very young age. When he celebrated his 60th birthday, he said, “Me too, I have reached that 60 years” and that he had never celebrated his birthday before until he was 60 years. As if it was prophetic—Only for us to wake up last weekend and be told that the man is no more.

Mr Speaker, Ghana should give him a befitting burial. The campaign song that my friend sang, that was a campaign song of the New Patriotic Party (NPP) in 2008. I remember that after the National Democratic Congress (NDC) won the elections, every party that the NDC had, that was the song they were singing. — Not the *aye huhuuu*—[Laughter]—The song, *Nana ye winner*. It was so popular across political parties that you did not know whether it was an NPP song or an NDC song. It was a model of how to campaign and how to compose a campaign song. Maybe the NDC brought one or two hit songs in 2012 to defeat us. But Mr Speaker, for him to produce so many musicians: Nana KD, Kofi B, Kofi Nti, and the one who sang “*Emmanuel*”—Ofori Amponsah—All of them, over 20 or 30 musicians passed through his hands.

This is a great man we have to celebrate. He has done his part for Ghana music. He is an icon; he is a legend and this is a man who is our Michael Jackson. Let us remember him and give him a befitting burial and pray that the almighty Lord will forgive him all his sins and put him at his right side.

If you listen to his interviews over the last 10 years, when he did the surgery and was having difficulties, he always used God first before any other thing. Maybe the ancestors of Ghana and the spirits of the Sekyere land, Ashanti land, were telling him that his time is up. But whatever it is, wherever he is today, he should know that the people of Ghana love him. I have a friend who says that we should sing, is it *Ankwanoma*?

[Mr Nitiwul and some Hon Members sang Daddy Lumba’s *Ankwanoma*.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, what is this?

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, we are doing things out of the ordinary for an extraordinary human being. Mr Speaker, forgive us, but we are mourning the best of the best. Forgive us, for we shall never forget the name Charles Kwadwo Fosu, also known as (a.k.a.) Daddy Lumba (D.L.). On that day, let all of us be present to mourn him, wherever the funeral will be held, whether in Nsuta, Kumasi, or Accra. But I wish the state will give him a state burial here at the Forecourt of the State House for the people of Ghana to come and mourn him. And I bet you the streets of Accra will be full.

I went to the gym today and everybody was playing Daddy Lumba songs. You move through all parts of Accra; people are playing Daddy Lumba songs. People are weeping from Ghana to Germany and people are weeping from Bolga to Accra. Some people who never wept for their family members wept when they heard that Daddy Lumba died and it is not because they knew him physically. Not many people even met him, but the fact that he brought joy to the hearts of many people in Ghana.

Mr Speaker, Lumba brought joy through music. We are doing politics. I believe we shall also bring joy through politics. But for Lumba, he has done his part. He is a great man and we should not forget Daddy Lumba. Lumba's incarnate will come one day. But I dare to say that he may arguably be the greatest Ghanaian musician to walk on the streets of Accra and to walk on the streets of Ghana.

I thank you, Mr Speaker, and may God bless all of us. And may his soul rest in perfect peace.

Ms Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe (NDC — Ada): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity and I would like to thank the maker of the Statement.

Mr Speaker, we have lost a legend. This is a man who brought joy to everybody in the world. Because his music is everywhere. His songs are played at funerals and weddings; the youth play his music. Even in politics, his music is there. Mr Speaker, Daddy Lumba will never die because his music

will continue to live on and because of that his name will continue to live on.

Mr Speaker, initially, I asked myself, why 60 years? Because I could remember I went to a programme with Mama Pat and we were invited to attend his 60th birthday but I could not go. Sixty years is too young because, if life begins at 40, then he is 20 years. When you listen to what killed him, initially people were saying the wife poisoned him, but he came out boldly to tell the whole world that it was a spinal cord injury. Mr Speaker, this tells us that we should take good care of ourselves. At our youthful age, we should save some of the energy for the future, for the retirement age. We should not waste all the youthful age and not reserve some for the future or our retirement age.

Mr Speaker, the spinal cord is a tissue that God has put together. So, we should take good care of it because this spinal cord injury has killed a lot of people, especially a lot of men. Mr Speaker, I would advise everybody, because recently I met a guy in the tunnel and looking at the load that boy was carrying, I stopped him and asked him if he knew he was injuring himself. When one is young, one feels strong.

4.52 p.m.

But by the time one starts ageing, one starts feeling the effects. So, one has to take good care of one's self when he or she is young. If one's weight is 60kg or 50 kg and one wants to put three cement bags, which is more than one's weight together and carry, one will injure himself

or herself. One is not going to feel the pain in one's arms the day one throws the stone, but will feel it later. So, it is a pity that at age 60 that he was supposed to enjoy—Even if he could not have played musical concerts in places again, this is the time he would have stayed home with the grandchildren to enjoy the fruits of his labour. But this is rather the time he is saying goodbye to Ghanaians.

It is sad. We are all sad because we are going to miss him a lot. As my Colleague said, we enjoyed a new song from him every Christmas. Mr Speaker, we must not do what will hurt us and break us down in future. As he himself said *me yere meho kum meho maa nipa o, enso wiase nipa nhu nea maye*—

To wit, a person will force and kill himself or herself for people and they would not even know what the person has done for them. So, a person must not force and kill himself or herself for people. A person must do what will give him or her more strength and energy, so that the person can stay and see his or her children, grandchildren, and great-grandchildren.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. *[Laughter]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Hon Members, may we observe one minute's silence.

[A minute's silence was observed for Charles Kwadwo Fosu (Daddy Lumba)]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, may his soul rest in perfect peace.

Hon Members, Statement time has ended. We now move to commencement of public Business.

Hon Members, can we turn to Order Paper *Addendum*—Presentation and First Reading. Minister for the Interior?

BILL — FIRST READING

Security and Intelligence Agencies Bill, 2025

AN ACT to provide for matters relating to the National Security Council to establish the regional security councils, the district security councils, to specify some of the state agencies responsible for coordinating and implementing Government policies on the security of the state and attendant issues on all relating to the internal and external security of Ghana and to provide for related matters.

Presented by the Minister for the Interior (Alhaji Mohammed-Mubarak Muntaka) (MP). Read the First time; referred to the Committee on Defence and Interior.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I think it should be referred to the Committee on Security and Intelligence and we could add the leadership of the Committee on Defence and Interior.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Then it is referred to the Committee on Security and Intelligence and they should be joined by the leadership of the Committee on Defence and Interior.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much for those corrections.

Hon Members, the item numbered 9, Motion. The Motion has been duly moved by the Minister for Finance. Any seconder?

MOTION

Mid-Year Budget Review, 2025

[Moved on Thursday, 24th July 2025 by the Hon Minister for Finance, Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson.]

Second Deputy Majority Whip (Mr Richard Acheampong): Mr Speaker, I rise to second the Motion.

Question proposed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I have the list before me. I would then proceed to give the floor to Hon Adjei Mensah?

Yes, Hon Habib Iddrisu?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Thank you, Mr Speaker. Mr Speaker, as important as the Mid-Year Budget Review is, the Hon Minister for Finance moved the Motion and it has just been duly seconded by the Second Deputy Majority Whip. We are debating the Mid-Year Budget Review of the Finance Ministry. The Hon Minister and his Deputy are not here.

Mr Speaker, if there are issues and serious concerns that will come from the debate, how will they be able to respond and take notice of that? This is unacceptable and they should take this House seriously. If the Majority Side are not ready to debate the Budget, they should say so. How can we debate the Mid-Year Budget Review without the Minister for Finance or his Deputy? How? Where are they?

Mr Speaker, we cannot. I do not know— The Minister for Roads and Highways is intimidating me with his looks. We need the Minister for Finance and his Deputy before we start this debate. The Majority Side must take this House seriously and take their own Budget seriously. How can we debate the Budget without the Minister or the Deputy Minister?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we shall come to the debate, but in the meantime, my attention has been drawn to Order Paper *Addendum 2*.

So, Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, we had some agreements today and you have been following it all along. So, Mr Speaker, we have not been engaged on this and we do not know anything about it. So, let us zoom into the debate. Later on, we can look at the Order Paper *Addendum 2*. You know we discussed it and we have been following it, so we cannot do the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection's Business at the moment.

So, Mr Speaker, let us continue with the debate then when we get to a certain point, we will be able to do it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib Iddrisu, this was one of the issues that we discussed, that there will be a withdrawal of the Bill and then representation of that particular Bill because the Bill is in this House. The Social Protection Bill has been introduced and referred to a Committee. So, it is one of the Businesses for us to carry. So, let us just permit her to do the needful, then we can refer it to a Committee and then come to the debate.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, I will plead with my Colleagues to allow the laying of the Papers, so that after that, we will talk about it. Because Mr Speaker, this is a straightforward matter.

5.02 p.m.

We do not need to belabour the point, so we are just pleading with them to allow us lay those Papers because the document is before the House and they are withdrawing it and, in place, lay the new one. So, I do not think there is any difficulty here. The Minister is here; she will provide the necessary answers to the questions that the Hon Member raised, so they should let her lay the Paper first and she will proceed by giving us the reasons why she is doing that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is not a new Business that the Minister is bringing.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, with respect to your good self, even when

they needed to withdraw the Energy Sector Levies (Amendment) (No.2) Bill, 2025, there was an engagement and we know why, but for the Minister and the Majority Frontbench to spring surprise on us—We do not know anything. Why is the Minister withdrawing? We have not been engaged and, Mr Speaker, with respect, we never discussed this issue and we are not aware. So, let us zoom into the debate; we will engage and, after that, within the debate, we can do this one.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, what I want to do is that we will allow the Minister to withdraw and present, so that when we refer it to the Committee, then we can engage within the period.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, the Bill is now the property of Parliament. Why is the Minister withdrawing it? We do not know anything, so they should engage.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is why, at the point of the withdrawal, the Minister will indicate why the Bill is being withdrawn. It is really the property of Parliament.

Yes, Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection?

BILL — WITHDRAWAL

Mid-Year Budget Review, 2025

Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection (Dr Agnes Naa Momo Lartey) (MP): Mr Speaker, I come under Order 173 to seek your leave and the

leave of the House to withdraw the Social Protection Bill, 2025 that was earlier made on the 27th June, 2025.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the application made for leave to withdraw the Social Protection Bill, 2025.

Hon Members, leave is accordingly granted and the Social Protection Bill, 2025 is consequentially withdrawn.

[The Social Protection Bill, 2025; withdrawn by leave of the House]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Now, Minister, go to the Order Paper *Addendum 2*, the item numbered 2, Presentation and First Reading.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I want to draw your attention to Standing Order 173(1), as the Minister quoted that a sponsor may withdraw a Bill by the leave of the House, not the leave of the Speaker. So, Mr Speaker, you cannot grant that leave to her. She definitely needs the leave of the House, not the leave of the Speaker and that is what the Standing Order says. So, Mr Speaker, the right thing should be done.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, if you read the Order carefully, when the Minister made the application, I threw the application back to the House, so if nobody opposes the application, the leave of the House can only come through the Speaker of the House. By this particular Order, we have been in this House for some time, I have not seen Members get up and say they have

granted a leave. It is only through the Speaker, so the right thing has been done. I said the leave of the House is being sought to withdraw the Bill. There was no opposition and once we do not have any opposition for it, then the leave must be granted. The leave of the House is normally communicated by the Speaker, so if a Member gets up to say that he or she is opposed to the leave being sought because of this or that, it is then that we can go into any debate.

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, I think what my Colleague was trying to say was that she was relying on an Order—And, he wanted her to just do the right thing by saying that she is seeking the leave of the House—*[Interruption]*—She said the leave of the Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: She actually mentioned the leave of the House and the leave of the Speaker—

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, did she mention both?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, she mentioned both; then, I said:

“Hon Members, the leave of the House is being sought.”

And there was no opposition.

Mr Nitiwul: That is understood. If she mentioned the leave of the House, that is all right.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: She quoted the right Order.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister came under Order 173. She mentioned that and Order 173 reads— Either the House or Mr Speaker, she came under 173. That settles the matter.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, we are all students of parliamentary procedure and, it is not the case that nobody objected to the leave that she sought. I did and I told you that we should go ahead to do the debate and come back even though you prevailed on me. Mr Speaker, seeking the leave of the House is different from seeking the leave of the Speaker. Order 173(1) says:

“A sponsor may withdraw a Bill by leave of the House”.

Mr Speaker, you are the one presiding and if you ask, you do not necessarily think that we will get up to say we oppose, but there is another way you could go by doing this whole thing. Mr Speaker, do you know why this Order is suffering? It is because there is no prior engagement to the whole thing. The Majority Frontbench is springing a surprise on us. That is why it is suffering. If there was an engagement, it will not, but one does not quote an Order and rely on it which, definitely, does not comply to this.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, for this one, I have been in the House for some time, but we have never taken decision when leave of the House is being sought by way of voting.

Hon Members, let us turn to Order Paper *Addendum* 2 and take the item

numbered 2, Presentation and First Reading of Bills.

BILL — FIRST READING

Social Protection Bill, 2025

AN ACT to promote access to social protection, provide social protection services to specified persons, establish and specify institutional arrangements to secure social protection and provide for related matters.

Presented by the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection (Dr Agnes Naa Momo Lartey). Read the First time; referred to the Committee on Gender, Children and Social Welfare.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, looking at the Bill, the new one is not *gazetted*, so I urge the Committee to determine the urgency or otherwise of the Bill and present that Report as well.

Yes, First Deputy Majority Whip?

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, we can start the debate on the Mid-Year Review, but the Hon Habib Iddrisu asked about the Minister or the Deputy. The Finance Committee, Budget Committee, and Committee on Economy and Development met this afternoon with the Minister, so he is trying to fine-tune the document that we requested from him. He will soon join us, so we can start the debate while the Deputy Minister fine-tunes the request that we put before him.

5.12 p.m.

So very soon, he will join us and sit through the debate—*[Interruption]* What did you say? Mr Speaker, he is not a Member of the Committee. The Ranking Member was not there. Ask Hon Kabiru, there was a meeting.

So, Mr Speaker, the Deputy Minister will join us, but we can start the debate.

Mr Matthew Nyindam: Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity.

I just listened to the Second Deputy Majority Whip, who talked about Committee matters here. Mr Speaker, the Budget Statement was presented to this House, which we are to debate, but none of the Ministers for Finance is here. We can pardon the substantive Minister for Finance, but his Deputy should make himself available, at least, to give respect to this House.

But for the Second Deputy Majority Whip to say that the Minister for Finance is unavoidably absent and his Deputy is working on a meeting that was held by a committee, so because of that he is not coming—Let us give respect to this House.

For us to debate the Budget Statement—*[Interruption]* Mr Speaker, whether we were here or not, this is the House; we belong here and we have every right to debate the Statement. Mr Speaker, I am sorry that today, the Minister for Roads and Highways is saying that we left. When he was the

Minority Chief Whip, he led his soldiers out of this House.

Mr Speaker, we are not debating without any of the Ministers. It would be an affront to this House for us to start a debate on the Budget without the Minister or, at least, the Deputy Minister.

Mr Speaker, I want to urge you not to succumb to their pressure. Mr Speaker, do not allow yourself to set a bad precedence. Do not let them put you under pressure. We want to respect this House, so we urge you to get the Deputy Minister for Finance in, for us to start the debate.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Matthew Nyindam, I know you are “I shall return”, but you have also been in the House for some time. Is it the case that when we are debating, the Minister or his Deputy must be present? Because the Motion is for the consideration of the House.

Mr Nyindam: Mr Speaker, we have conventions and practices in this House and we, obviously, have our Standing Orders as a guide. If we are debating a Budget, at least, for the first day—Mr Speaker, like you said, “I shall return”, not just I shall return—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, can you guide me with the Standing Orders you quoted?

Mr Nyindam: Mr Speaker, that is why I said, it is not just by our Standing

Orders only. We are talking about conventions and practices; some of them are not codified, but we use them as our conventions and practices. What I am saying is that I know I have been here and I have had the opportunity to also become a Leader, and for any debate on the Budget Statement that we take on this Floor, at least, on the first day, one of the Ministers will represent.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I intend to suspend the House for 30 minutes. The House is accordingly suspended.

5.16 p.m. — Sitting suspended.

6.02 p.m. — Sitting resumed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, by the Business of the House that we have adopted, the time allotted to Chairmen is 15 minutes. Vice Chairmen and Ranking Members have 10 minutes and Members have five minutes.

Hon Members, this is what the House has agreed upon. I would not want a situation where your time is up and you still want to continue. I would have no hesitation in drawing your attention to the rules and if you go further and push me against the wall, I would not want to fall down. Then you know the implications. So, I would not want that. Once we have agreed on the time, let us all help ourselves regarding the time. Let us go by it and the debate will flow very smoothly. We do not have any time for heckling. Let me emphasise; there would be no time for

heckling. You should be mindful heckling may lead you into a disorderly conduct. So, Hon Members, thank you very much.

We proceed with the debate. For today, we are starting with the Majority and probably tomorrow we will start with the Minority. So, I will proceed to give the floor to Mr Adjei Mensah. Hon, you are a Chairperson, so you have 15 minutes.

MOTION

Mid-Year Budget Review, 2025

[Resumption of Debate from Column 51]

Mr Isaac Adjei Mensah (NDC—Wassa East): Mr Speaker, thank you for giving me the opportunity to contribute to the debate on the Mid-Year Fiscal Policy Review of the Government of Ghana for the 2025 financial year as presented by Dr Cassiel Ato Forson, Member of Parliament (MP) and Minister for Finance, which was ably delivered on Thursday, 24th July, 2025.

Mr Speaker, this is one of the finest and the sharpest presentations of Mid-Year Review by Dr Ato Forson. Indeed, the manner in which he presented the Review programme was fantastic. It is one of the most intelligent ones and I am honoured to be associated with this debate.

Mr Speaker, if one considers the introductory delivery, he talked about the macroeconomic performance for January to June 2025, the global development and outlook, and indeed the fiscal performance. These are areas that were

wonderfully and properly presented. I will concentrate on the Big Push, the road sector, and the recently passed Bill, the Road Maintenance Trust Fund Bill, 2025.

Mr Speaker, we are all aware of the road situation in this country and the mid-year delivery, to a very large extent, put an end to the so-called drama relating to roads in the past; Year of Roads 1, Year of Roads 2 and Year of Roads 3, where we did not see anything or there was nothing to show. This key delivery by the Minister shows where we are and where we are going in the road sector.

Mr Speaker, in the past, we had cause to complain about the performance in the road sector to the extent that there was evidence to show that the maintenance regime was very poor. All our roads were in a very bad state, and indeed we were all concerned. But along the line, there came some reports that our roads were good—Our roads were bad, and MPs and many people, were complaining about our roads. To the extent that we had reports that indicated that the previous government, the New Patriotic Party (NPP) had performed and indeed constructed more roads than any other government. Some of us had concern to debate to the extent that we thought those were not realistic and were not true and should not be taken to be serious. So, now we are in power and all the records are in the Ministry. That is a Herculean task for the Minister of Roads and Highways now. All details there are in a very negative situation. Therefore, the Big Push is to give hope, resolve all these inadequacies and all the vacuum of non-performance in the Sector.

Mr Speaker, the Big Push as we all know, is an initiative by President Mahama for massive infrastructure development in this country. Why I am concentrating on the Big Push now is that it has been indicated in the 2025 Budget. It was indicated that President Mahama has dedicated Big Push Budget allocation for two years to the road sector alone and that means that we are going to see enough improvement in that sector. The Minister indicated about 32 critical roads across the country and these roads are going to be handled by the Big Push. If two consecutive budgetary allocations for the Big Push are all going to be dedicated to the road sector, that tells us that this Government is very serious. We also identified about 13 critical roads which were abandoned by the previous government. They were part of the Year of Roads 1, Year of Roads 2 and Year of Roads 3 that we never saw any improvement. These areas have also been earmarked for action.

Mr Speaker, the Minister indicated that his engineers and the Ministry staff for the past six months have dedicated their time and energies into engineering of all roads so that they will be properly laid down for action under the Big Push.

Mr Speaker, we also have the issue relating to the Road Maintenance Trust Fund Bill, 2025 that will also give hope. It gives clarity and indeed it will also show fairness and equity in the distribution of the Fuel Levy. So we know that the appropriate formula will be in place to ensure that all regions, districts and constituencies will all have their fair share of the details.

Mr Speaker, in the presentation, it was also made clear that the road toll is coming back. Indeed, the road toll which was abolished by the previous government – there were a lot of promises which were made that it was coming back but it never came back. This Review and of course in the Budget, the promise was there and the concern now is that the Minister has gone through the process and getting to almost pressing the button for us to get whoever is going to handle the road toll and all this will come into the main Trust Fund.

6.12 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the coming into effect of this Road Maintenance Trust Fund—the old Road Fund is now more or less repealed and is no longer in force. The Road Maintenance Trust Fund is going to give us hope and ensure sustained resources and programmes for the maintenance of our roads going forward.

Mr Speaker, in the budget presentation, we were made aware that 166 districts or constituencies have been earmarked for action. For every year, 10 km of roads will be constructed in every district that has been earmarked. And basically, if they are 160 communities, Mr Speaker, what it tells us is that it is virtually across the country. It is not the grading that used to be counted in the past government; it is not 10 km that is going to be graded, Mr Speaker, it is 10 km that is going to be constructed. If it is an already existing road, it is going to be maintained in terms of bituminisation and that is going to happen. In fact, Mr

Speaker, you would recall that all MPs, were happy to the extent that some of the new ones nearly clapped instead of [*Hear! Hear!*] They never wanted the Minister to stop.

So, you can see the three trenches. One, Mr Speaker, is the Big Push and two is Road Maintenance Trust Fund that has been established and three, the fact that about 166 constituencies or districts have been earmarked for that. But apart from that, it is critical for us to know that 32 critical roads across the country, these are massive roads and bridges— In addition to the fact that about 13 of the critical roads and one is in Takoradi, the Paa Grant Interchange and all those others where we had a lot of news are going to be constructed going forward. So, I think those of us who were here and those of us who were monitoring—I know our Colleagues were monitoring on the television because they never had the opportunity to have a full view of it. But it is one of the finest presentations.

So, you would realise that the six-months period of President Mahama's administration has demonstrated—so much to show. The economy has been stabilised, the cedi has been critically maintained. The cedi-dollar relationship is fantastic; it is super. And that tells us the smartest way of handling the economy and it is not that, you will be reading; I was worried. I thought that the Minister was probably going to be quoting from the Bible, Jeremiah and so on. This never happened. So this Minister's intelligence in a smart manner, demonstrated to us where we are going. So, it gives us hope. The question is that

what do we have ahead of us? For me and for us in the road sector, it is clear that our road conditions are going to be maintained and going to be constructed properly. Most of us here have our roads within the 166 communities and the 32 critical roads and bridges are going to be sorted out.

Mr Speaker, we talk about the Big Push Programme. The two consecutive budget allocations that are going to be dedicated to the road sector tell you how serious President Mahama is. And of course, for the past six months, the Minister indicated, and I have been monitoring that as a Committee— The Minister has always been busy. If one does not catch him on time, one will not get him. He is always going around, combing the whole country; moving front and back. So the Report of the Key Performance Indicators (KPI) that the Minister enumerated here is a commitment because the Minister also said that he has given commitment authorisations.

Mr Speaker, when we talk about commitment authorisations, it is not a commencement certificate, it is commitment authorisation. It means that enough allocations, plans and room is made for all these roads to be constructed. And it is not just a hearsay or a mouth say, like the Year of Roads One, Year of Roads Two and Year of Roads Three. These are critical roads—These are actionable situations where; indeed, they are there and it is a fact that one can, at any particular point in time, ask about — One will have the roads there. And so, when commitment authorisation has been

given for all these roads to be performed on, one can just ask their questions appropriately.

In the past— Mr Speaker, this budget is also clear and in fact, it gives hope. One would remember that we talked about the fact that we never even know how many kilometres we have in terms of our road network. As we speak now, we cannot tell. All we have are projections. The Minister in the Budget has made reasonable allocation for the road condition mix survey to be conducted so that at the end of the day, we will be able to tell Ghanaians given the Big Push Programme coming in, and the fact that the Minister and his engineers have taken pains to demonstrate to us that the totality of our road network is (X), and this is where we are going.

So, we are happy that, when we get to the end of the year, our road condition will be better, proper and in terms of fineness, they will be okay, and little will be left as bad. Mr Speaker, I am very confident that, by the end of the term, our road situation will be found in a very good shape. A lot of Members of Parliament have asked questions about their roads, and the Minister has come to answer them. And the sort of hope that he gave, I wish they were all here to listen to the Minister. If you check through the budget review, it is all about roads. The hope is there that our roads are going to be fixed. It is not just a mouth saying; they are actionable details. Budgetary allocations have been made for it and I think at a particular point in time, we can ask for that.

Mr Speaker, I think in the budget, the Minister also indicated that when he came here to read the budget, about 13.8 billion was dedicated for the Big Push and so the President says that for the next two years, the US\$13.8 billion every year, put together two years of budgetary allocation, all these are going to be devoted to road construction—the road sector. That tells you that the hope is given. So your roads are going to be constructed. They are going to be maintained. And once again, we will come into the good light of road performance in this country.

Mr Speaker, before I sit down, I think that it is also important to make reference to this. Once upon a time, there was Mahama's period—the Green Book. When the Green Book was unveiled, there were roads which were constructed—clearly constructed. But my friends were asking, where are the roads? Where are the roads? This time around, we have tabulated the roads. We have indicated the number of roads that we are going to construct and we have given the timelines. The Road Maintenance Trust Fund is also in and dedicated funds are going to be given. I think that we should pray that God blesses President Mahama. Long live President Mahama. Long live NDC. Long live Ghana.

Thank you, Mr Speaker. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. I will now give the floor to Hon Amin Adams.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, he started from four minutes. So check the time on the console. He started from four minutes.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you are not my timekeeper. The clerks are keeping the time.

Yes, Hon Amin Adams?

Dr Mohammed Amin Adam (NPP—Karaga): Mr Speaker, on July 24th this year, the Minister for Finance presented the Mid-Year Report on the budget implementation for 2025, and I am surprised to read that we are going to approve the Mid-Year Budget.

The Minister has not come to this House with a supplementary budget. And so I am wondering what we are going to approve. He has not asked for additional money to spend. So I do not understand what we are going to approve. If it is because of the multi-year commitment they want for the projects, the budget for that has already been allocated in the 2025 Budget. The GHC13.8 billion we are talking about was already provisioned in the budget for 2025. And so, they should come very well for us to consider those multi-year commitments they want us to approve. But not as part of a budget that has been approved and that has provision for those projects.

Moreover, Mr Speaker, they have just brought us a list of projects. We do not know how much each is going to cost us. We do not know. So what are we going to approve?

6.22 p.m.

They have sent out a list of projects, but there is no amount dedicated to each of these projects. We do not know the contractors that are going to do it. So how do we approve this multi-year commitments that they have brought to this House? So, this cannot be part of the Mid-Year Budget report on the implementation of a 2025 Budget, because it is not a supplementary Budget. So, I am really at a loss why we are talking about approval.

But Mr Speaker, having said this, I listened to my Brother, the respected Majority Leader, after the Hon Minister presented the Mid-Year report—*[Interruption]* I watched it on television. Mr Speaker, I listened to him and the Hon Majority Leader, Mr Mahama Ayariga, a distinguished lawyer, said that he had never listened to a Budget presentation like what he listened to that day. And he was happy that for the first time, a Budget was being presented without Bible quotations. Did he say that or not?

Mr Speaker, I know why the Hon Minister did not bring Bible quotations. I know my Hon Brother, Dr Cassiel Ato Forson is a good Christian and I would have been surprised if he quoted Bible verses to support that propaganda piece that he brought to this House to consider. A Budget which is a propaganda piece laced with half-truths, and in most cases, untruths; and he would have quoted the Bible to support such a propaganda piece? I would have been very surprised.

But Mr Speaker, if we would recall, during the debate on the main 2025 Budget, I expressed my disappointment at the inadequate provisions made to fund the Government priority projects, what they call their flagship projects: Adwumawura, Nkoko Nketenkete and Feed Ghana Programme; I was really surprised. The Mid-Year Budget presented by the Hon Minister has somehow confirmed my fear. This is because I have looked at all the releases made towards these priority projects, and I am so sad that the Hon Minister has not shown enough commitment to fund this project that they promised the people of Ghana.

Mr Speaker, looking at the National Apprenticeship Programme, they provisioned GH¢300 million. The Hon Minister has released GH¢21 million. He has released just GH¢21 million for half of the year. That is just seven per cent of what the Hon Minister allocated towards that project. When we look at the Adwumawura programme, the Hon Minister allocated GH¢100 million, but he has released GH¢34.5 million, 34.5 per cent for half of the year. They allocated GH¢1.5 billion for Agriculture for Economic Transformation Agenda (AETA), under which we have the Feed Ghana programme, Ghana Grains Development Project, Vegetable Development Project, and the Nkoko Nketenkete Project. Mr Speaker, it is sad to know that the Hon Minister has not released GH¢1 towards the implementation of this programme.

Mr Speaker, they allocated GH¢51.3 million to the Women's Development

Bank, but they have released zero. Mr Speaker, they allocated GH¢100 million for the One Million Coders Programme, but they have not released GH¢1, half-way into the year. Mr Speaker, they allocated GH¢13.8 billion to the Big Push Programme, the programme my Colleague on the other Side just spoke about, but they have not released GH¢1 towards the implementation of the Big Push Programme. This is an important programme the National Democratic Congress (NDC) is touting around. I am shocked that after half of the year, after the Budget was presented, they have not even found it necessary to release funds for the implementation of this Programme. They are now doing procurements, I understand.

Mr Speaker, when the Hon Minister presented the list of road projects to be done under the Big Push, 45 of them, I was so sad; I did not see a single road project for my region, the Northern Region. Mr Speaker, in spite of all the support the NDC got from the Northern Region, not a single one was mentioned. I understand, this morning, after we spoke about this over the last three days, they brought a supplementary and now brought two small road projects, the Tamale Ring Road Project, and added that to the list this morning.

Mr Speaker, we should not be toying with the trust of the people of Ghana. They have won so much support from the region and on an important project like the Big Push, they did not put a single road from that region under that project. I am happy that this morning they brought a supplementary to correct this anomaly.

Mr Speaker, apart from the Big Push, we remember they brought the Ghana Gold Board Act, 2025 here under certificate of urgency, and the Hon Minister allocated US\$279 million. As I speak to the House, the Hon Minister has not released a cent for the operations of the Gold Board; not a cent. All the funds the Gold Board has used so far has come from the Bank of Ghana. The Bank of Ghana has pre-financed the operations of the Gold Board and has pre-financed the purchases of gold. The Hon Minister has not released a cent from the Budget of US\$279 million that he allocated in the Budget.

Mr Speaker, as for the 24-Hour Economy, which was launched recently, a beautiful document was shown to the whole world with very nice pictures, just like the Green Book that we saw in the first term of President Mahama. But sad to say, Mr Speaker, there is no budget to implement it. I said this while we were debating the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, and the Hon Minister, in this Mid-Year Budget Review, has confirmed that he is now going to provide for the implementation in the 2026 Budget. Mr Speaker, why would they run to launch programmes? They have launched Feed Ghana Programme, but they have not released funds. They have launched 24-Hour Programme but no budget to implement it.

Mr Speaker, let us take the people of Ghana seriously. When we promise them and we allocate money to implement what we promised them, we should do it, show that commitment, release the funds,

so that the people of Ghana can benefit from this programme.

Mr Speaker, it is important because the Hon Minister is not releasing funds towards the implementation of this programme, there is no money out there. I came from my constituency yesterday, the farmers told me they have farm produce, but nobody is buying it; there is no money. The Hon Minister must release the funds for the implementation of these programmes.

Mr Speaker, I know why the Hon Minister is not releasing the funds. Because the Hon Minister launched 28 treasury auctions over the last six months and 13 of them were failures; auction shortfalls. My Brothers and Sisters on the other Side, all the 13 had bid-to-cover ratio of less than one. Mr Speaker, the money the Hon Minister would have released to implement this programme, he has never used that money to pay the shortfalls amounting to billions of Ghana cedis. Who caused it?

The Hon Minister used artificial means to bring the interest rates and the coupon on the treasury bills down, yet there was no coordination with the Bank of Ghana. How is it possible that we have such huge misalignment between fiscal policy and monetary policy? The Hon Minister is borrowing at 15 per cent, and now I understand 10 per cent, while the Bank of Ghana is borrowing at 28 per cent. What a huge misalignment! Because of that, the people have resorted to buying the bills from the Bank of Ghana, instead of patronising the treasury bills of the Hon Minister. Because of that, the Hon

Minister has to divert resources meant to implement Nkokɔ Nketenkete Project and Adwumawura Programme to go and pay for the shortfalls that he has caused himself. Mr Speaker, this is not how we manage an economy.

6.32 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister also, in presenting the Mid-Year Budget Review, tried to claim successes he does not deserve. Firstly, he reported that he had brought down Ghana's debt to GDP ratio from 61.8 per cent at the end of 2024 to 43 per cent in just six months. Laudable, is it not? But the question I ask the Minister was how much of Ghana's debt has he repaid in six months? That is zero! He has not repaid any cedi of Ghana's debt stock in six months.

So, if Ghana's debt to GDP ratio has come down from 61.8 per cent to 43 per cent, is it the work of the Minister? And when I say this, they say they paid coupons to Euro bondholders and Domestic Debt Exchange Programme (DDEP) bondholders. I am talking about debt stock, not talking about flow. The debt stock has reduced not because they have repaid any of the debts of Ghana to reduce the debt stock. The debt stock has reduced because of the work the previous NPP Government did. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Speaker, it is no secret that I led the negotiation with the Euro bondholders, and at the end of the negotiation, we reached a deal that led to the outright cancellation of US\$ 5 billion. [*Hear! Hear!*] And we got debt service

savings of another US\$4.7 billion. Mr Speaker, when we talk about reduction in the debt stock, that is what we are talking about. What has the Minister done in six months which is similar to what we did when we were in government to bring the debt stock of our country down?

Mr Speaker, this Minister, in opposition, criticised us for doing the debt restructuring exercise and then he has come into government and he turns around to clap and claim credit for the product of the exercise that he condemned. How does he criticise an exercise and wants to praise himself for the product of that exercise? Mr Speaker, that is not acceptable.

Mr Speaker, again, the Minister reported—*[Interruption]* Mr Speaker, somebody is disturbing my mind. Mr Speaker, the Minister again reported that Ghana has earned an upgrade by Fitch and he is claiming credit for the Fitch Rating upgrade. Mr Speaker, let me read what Fitch itself has said in their statement when they upgraded Ghana and I quote:

“The upgrade of Ghana’s long-term foreign currency, IDR, to B- from RD reflects Fitch’s assessment...”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up.

Hon Members, the IT Department is keeping the time for us, so once your time is up, your microphone will automatically be off.

I will then proceed to give the floor to Hon Jean-Marie Formadi. You have five minutes.

Ms Jean-Marie Formadi (NDC — Biakoye): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for giving me the opportunity to debate the Mid-Year Fiscal Policy brilliantly delivered by the Minister for Finance. Mr Speaker, the Mid-Year Budget that was ably delivered on behalf of H. E. John Dramani Mahama is the best ever in the history of Ghana. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, the road sector is a sector that Ghanaians are so much interested in because everything that one does—The moment one steps out of their door, one steps onto the road, either with a vehicle, on foot, or motorbike and wherever one is going, he or she uses the road. So, it is very important that a Fund is allocated to road projects in this country.

Mr Speaker, unlike the previous Government that announced Year of Roads projects and we did not see the roads they talked about and also left over GH¢21 billion as debt, Mr Speaker, the approved revenue from oil and also the mineral royalties have been allocated to the Big Push that will be used for the construction of roads, so that roads will not be abandoned due to non-allocation of funds for the construction of these roads. Mr Speaker, when you look at the Big Push where GH¢13.8 billion has been allocated to roads, 32 roads across the country will be catered for by that Fund. Like I said earlier, there is a dedicated

Fund to the roads that will be constructed, so those roads will not be abandoned. When all these roads are constructed, market women will be free from transporting their goods to the markets from the farm gates to the markets. The cars that are on our roads will not be rickety because shocks will not be spoilt any time that they use their roads.

Mr Speaker, when drivers keep changing shocks, it will put burden on their pocket. We are very grateful to the President for taking roads as projects and we have a very dedicated and hardworking Minister for Roads and Highways who we all believe will deliver on the roads that have been outlined to be constructed.

Mr Speaker, when you look at the Budget, it made us believe that 166 constituencies will have 10 kilometres of roads constructed every year. If the previous Government had constructed, at least, one kilometre of road per year in our constituencies, by now, the moneys that are being allocated from our oil revenue and mineral royalties will be used for something else. But here we are, because all the roads that they claimed they have done have not been done, those moneys are still being used to fix our roads. And we are grateful to the President for taking our roads as a priority and Ghanaians will be happy because roads are what we use in doing everything. Like I said earlier, we go to everywhere—When one is going to work, he or she uses the road; if a person is going to the market, he or she uses the road. Everywhere that a person is going, he or she uses the road. So, when our

roads are fixed, everybody will be happy—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up.

Ms Formadi: So, we are grateful that the President— [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I will give the floor to Hon Abena Osei-Asare. She is a Chairperson, so she has 15 minutes.

Mrs Abena Osei-Asare (NPP—Atiwa East): Mr Speaker, I must commend my Colleague on the other Side. This is the first time the National Democratic Congress (NDC) is allowing a woman to debate on the first— [**Members of the Majority:** Boo! Boo!]
—Yes, let me finish.

Mr Speaker, this is the first time, when it comes to economic policy, they are allowing a Lady to debate right after the Ranking Member.

6.42 p.m.

Mr Speaker, that notwithstanding, let me congratulate Hon Jean-Marie Formadi for speaking right after the Ranking Member.

Mr Speaker, but let me say that we have reached a point where it is not about numbers. Numbers alone cannot lead; numbers alone cannot tell the story. Beyond the graphs, the interest rates and all those things, let us ask ourselves, what is the real impact of the Mid-Year Budget

Review? Because Ghanaians do not live in the Budget; they live in their economy.

Mr Speaker, the Minister brought the Mid-Year Budget Review to this House full of technical jargons, but when they look in their pockets, their shopping baskets, utility bills, among others, they do not feel the relief the Minister talked about. So, we need to go beyond the numbers and let our people feel in their pockets what relief they claim they have brought.

The Minister came here to churn out a lot of technical success stories. Inflation is down from 23.8 per cent to 13.7 per cent in six months. The Minister claims they have reduced debts from GH¢727 billion to GH¢613 billion, but let us ask ourselves, how is this reflecting in the pockets of Ghanaians? Mr Speaker, without any prudent measure, like the Ranking Member said, through some means of the cedi appreciating against our foreign currencies, the Minister has been able to bring the debt down by GH¢113 billion.

But, Mr Speaker, this is not about fiscal discipline; it is just about arithmetic. It is not about fiscal discipline. Just by purporting that the cedi has strengthened against the dollar, so by virtue of that, they have done something that has brought the debt down and we should clap for them; Ghanaians are not feeling that in their pockets as well.

Mr Speaker, the Minister also said that by virtue of what he has done, he has been able to bring down domestic interest rates by GH¢4.9 billion because the cedi

has appreciated against the dollar by about 42 per cent. So, in that same measure, our external interest payments should go down, but what do we see in the numbers? It has gone up by 1 billion and that is why I keep saying, let us go beyond the numbers because if they tell us the cedi has appreciated against the dollar by 42 per cent, our interest payments should also come down. Why is it that in the revised budgets, our external interest payment has gone up by a billion? *[Interruption]* Thank you very much. Very artificial.

Mr Speaker, Government claims they are spending in the right places. They are spending in the right places, but the oil that Government will use to sort of generate the activities in the various Ministries, Departments and Agencies (MDAs), what do we see? Government budgeted about GH¢3 billion for the first half of the year for the MDAs as their goods and services. What do we see? Over GH¢1 billion, so you ask yourself, how are they working?

They claim they are spending in the right places; look at their capital expenditure. They budgeted GH¢32 billion for their capital expenditure. Look at what they have done, Mr Speaker, nothing. GH¢7.1 billion. They are spending at the right places—Contractors are crying, infrastructure is down and they claim they are spending at the right places?

They have GH¢32 billion as their capital expenditure for the year and seven months down the line, they have only spent GH¢7.1 billion. Do they call these

the right places? Mr Speaker, if they pay statutory payments, they have done nothing because it is statutory. They ought to pay. But how about the discretionary payments that they need to make? That is not there.

Again, Mr Speaker, the Minister claims they are spending at the right places. Look in the Mid-Year Budget Review, Ghana Revenue Authority (GRA) overshot their own half-year spending by GHC2.38 billion to GHC2.4 billion. The GRA went up over and above their spending and the Minister claims he is spending at the right places. Right under the nose of the Hon Minister, this is what is happening, so how can the Minister come here and tell us, he is spending at the right places? The GRA that is supposed to collect revenues on our behalf has ended up spending more than has been allocated to them in the Budget.

Mr Speaker, we have talked about the Big Push. This is worrying because if they tell Ghanaians they are coming up with a policy that they would spend US\$10 billion in four years and all they can do is less than a billion in the first year, and even with that, availability of funds is difficult. Look in the numbers. The numbers will tell you that they have not done anything substantial. If the Minister tells us that we are spending in the right places, we go beyond the numbers to see what the Minister has actually done.

Mr Speaker, again, the Hon Ranking Member mentioned the non-spending

under the Gold Board. Meanwhile, there are a lot of classrooms that need upgrades, even common chalk, hospital gloves, and so on. So, if they ring-fence this huge amount of money that can be used for equally important things and give it to the Gold Board and it is just there, not being used, and they claim that they are allocating and spending at the right places, this is where the Minister has gone wrong. Talk, indeed, they say, is cheap.

Mr Speaker, let us also go to the revenue numbers. It is also peddling a lot of untruths in here. We were in this Chamber when the Minister came under a certificate of urgency to introduce the popularly known revenue measure called the “D-Levy”. In discussions with the Finance Committee and on this Floor, the Minister told us that this particular revenue measure was going to raise about GHC5.7 billion.

So, the Minister, in revising the revenue numbers—When we look in the Budget, the Minister is telling us that the GHC5.7 billion that assuming he even collects it for just five months, he should get about GHC2.3 billion, he has only put in there GHC1.1 billion—*[Interruption]* Thank you very much. Something that was supposed to give him a minimum of GHC2.2 billion, then the Minister puts GHC1.1 billion, he is able to raise the GHC2.2 billion and he says, pat me on the back because I have exceeded my revenue. Mr Speaker, this is the untruth I am talking about.

But when we look at the revenue numbers that have been revised, the

Minister is adding GH¢2 billion to the revenue numbers. So, where is the Minister getting that GH¢2 billion from when he has only allocated GH¢1.1 billion? This is what I am talking about, that the revenue numbers are peddling a lot of untruths.

Mr Speaker, again, on the growth numbers, the Minister said First Quarter (Q1) saw a growth of about 5.5 per cent of GDP and that this growth is being led by agriculture, which is 6.6 per cent. But, Mr Speaker, what do we see on the market? Ask for the price of plantain and not aroma rice. Ask for the price of cassava and not all the sophisticated things the Minister announced here. You ask for the price and it tells you that clearly, they are not feeling it on the ground.

The Minister also mentioned that he is trying to see how he can reduce the items in the inflation baskets, so they are going to work on food prices. In one hand, he says he is trying very hard and he is going to introduce policies that will increase food production and on the other hand, he is bringing a measure that will increase transport fares by more than 30 or 40 per cent. So, you see the disconnect. There is no connection between policies and that is what the Minister ought to address and not to come here and say all the nice words, but, in actual fact, it is nothing and results in nothing.

Mr Speaker, we were here when the Minister said that the Ghana Reference Rate has moved from 29.3 per cent to 24 per cent. So, when he talks about inflation moving from 23.8 per cent to 13 per cent,

but the Ghana Reference Rate is what the households and small businesses feel. That is why he stood here and pleaded with traders and manufacturers to reduce the price of their goods because clearly, he knows they are not feeling it, so he had to come here and beg or ask them to do that.

One other thing that the Minister said is that we are no more going to quote items in foreign currency and that from the day he read the Mid-Year Budget Review, we should put a stop to it. But I remember very well that last year, the Chairperson of the Finance Committee told us that we should not mind anybody who tells not to keep our money in dollars, but we here are law-abiding citizens. We love our country. We will heed to what the Hon Minister has said and make sure we do everything possible to contribute our bit to help strengthen the cedi against the dollar.

6.52 p.m.

Mr Speaker, let me tell my Colleagues on the other Side that in the last election, Ghanaians said one thing; they gave them capital. This capital that Ghanaians have given to them, it is to be used for their benefits, otherwise we all know what will happen. So, I am urging them, it is not about just churning out numbers, but numbers that mean and will reflect positively in the lives of the people of Ghana. So Mr Speaker, just a little advice to the Minister; a very honest advice to the Minister, that he should not take the capital that Ghanaians have given to him for granted. Rather, it should inure to the benefits of Ghanaians. So seriously, if the

Minister wants to build the economy away from all the noise, away from all the propaganda that has gone on, I will urge the Minister to look at these. To make sure that the energy sector is well restructured and they have proper key performance indicators (KPIs).

Also, they should make sure that they make the revenue collection system fit for purpose, so that clearly— when you look at the revenue numbers, there was a shortfall, but if really they want to hit their target of GH¢229 billion that they have put in the revised Budget, then they should make sure that they implement both compliance measures and measures that I believe will reduce human intervention and help them rake in the revenues that they want to raise.

Also, one advice I want to give to the Minister is that anybody who has breached the Public Financial Management Act (PFMA) should be sanctioned. This is the way to go. This is a genuine advice for the Minister if they want to set the economy on the right path.

One other thing that the Minister kept talking about on Thursday was the issue of payroll. The Minister will have to find a lasting solution to it. I believe Ghanaians are open-minded and will be willing to help the Minister find a lasting solution to this. The Minister said payroll had gone over and above its target by GH¢1.3 billion, but when the Minister was revising the target, the Minister left the target as it is.

Mr Speaker, to conclude, I am a bit worried because when you look at the

Statutory Fund's revised amounts or the revision in the Budget, if we are going to add at least GH¢2 billion to our revenue numbers, that should also reflect in the Statutory Fund numbers, but that is nil. There is nothing but we were here when a Colleague on the other Side took the Government to court for the calculation of total revenue, so that if you are adding on GH¢2 billion to your revenues, why is it not reflecting in your revised Budget? The Minister has to come and answer to the people of Ghana that they are shortchanging Ghana Education Trust Fund (GETFund); they are shortchanging District Assemblies Common Fund (DA CF); they are shortchanging National Health Insurance Authority (NHIA). But Mr Speaker, we love this nation. We on this Side love this nation —[Uproar]— We want the nation to succeed, so whatever it takes to help the Minister, whatever it takes to help to make sure we have a Budget that can be implemented, a Budget that people will fill in their pockets, a Budget that people will say yes, the political capital that we gave to the NDC people, they have been able to use it to our benefit. Mr Speaker, that is all we are asking for and that is why we will support them to make sure the people of Ghana are not shortchanged.

Thank you very much. [Hear! Hear!]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you. The floor is now given to Hon Eric Afful; you have 15 minutes.

Dr Eric Afful (NDC — Amenfi West): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to make a contribution to the

presentation of the Mid-Year Budget Review.

Mr Speaker, before I make any statement on this, the statement made by the last speaker, Hon Isaac Adongo, the Chairman of the Finance Committee, that Ghanaians should not be allowed to withdraw dollars or any hard currency from the counter for transaction, is an error. This is a statement that should be expunged from the record, because he is not here to defend it. *[Uproar]*

She also made a statement that this is the first time a lady Member of Parliament has contributed to a Budget Review. *[Uproar]* Mr Speaker, I also say that this should be expunged before I go forward.

Mr Speaker, let me put on record that the actual performance of the 2025 Budget Statement within the last six months is historic. It is unprecedented. Mr Speaker, she was saying that we should not use figures. Mr Speaker, what should we use to judge the performance of the Budget? It is through the economic indicators. Is it not true that the economy grew by 5.3 per cent within the first quarter of 2025? Is it not true? Is it not true that you left 4.9 per cent? Mr Speaker, this was even done by the increase in the Agricultural sector, 6.6 per cent. Mr Speaker, is it not true that they left the inflation in this country at 23.8 per cent? It is down to 13.7 per cent. Is that not remarkable? It is a remarkable figure. Even food inflation is down to 16.3 per cent from 27.8 per cent. Mr Speaker, is it not true that imported inflation has come down to 12.5 per cent from 18 per cent?

You have to use the figures to adjudge the performance of the Budget. You cannot say that. Is it not true that, the lending rate has come down to 27 per cent from 30.3 per cent? Is it not true that the fiscal deficit within the first quarter of the year is about 7.7 per cent of GDP? Meanwhile, they left 1.8 per cent of GDP. Is it not true that the exchange rate, the cedi has appreciated 42.6 per cent? Is it not true that the cedi has appreciated 30.3 per cent against the pound sterling? Is it not true that the cedi has appreciated 25.6 per cent against the euro? So, what again?

Mr Speaker, what is more interesting is that we have imported inflation coming down. The primary balance, if you do not know, is 1.1 per cent of GDP as we speak today. So, the economy is growing. You can adjudge performance of budget through economic indicators so, my Sister, next time, do not say that again. Mr Speaker, the Government is being financially disciplined and spending wisely.

Mr Speaker, the gross international reserves, that is where I am more interested in. The gross international reserves asset now stands at US\$11.12 billion. Go and check it. Which gives us 4.8 months of import cover of goods and services. Meanwhile, they left it at US\$8.98 billion in December 2024, which gives us only 4.0 months of import cover of goods and services. So, Mr Speaker, the economy is doing well. Trade surplus is also positive.

7.02 p.m.

Going forward, Mr Speaker, let me say that the debt portfolio should also be

taken. They left a debt hanging of GHC726.7 billion, and we have been able to bring it down to GHC613 billion within a span of six months; we have brought it down by GHC113.7 billion. Give us some time, and it will go down further.

Mr Speaker, with the debt-to-GDP ratio, they left it at 61.8 per cent. Because of these measures, we have brought it down to 43.8 per cent—[Hear! Hear!]
So, it is remarkable and we should applaud this Government.

Mr Speaker, leaving the macro-economic indicators, I have heard my Friends from the other Side say that this Government is not spending, which is why we have favourable economic conditions, good economic indices. Mr Speaker, they should take it from me today that it is technically wrong. It is practically wrong, and in theory, it is also wrong because we are defiling the good principles of macroeconomics. Government expenditure is an injector. It is not a leakage. It injects income into the country. The Government appropriating GHC293 billion for the 2025 Fiscal Year means that we are injecting this money into the economy, which has a lot of multiplying effects. It will go into the pockets of Ghanaians.

Mr Speaker, let me be frank and tell Ghanaians that the success being chalked by this Government is through fiscal credibility the Government has gained from the people by implementing fiscal consolidation programmes, which has made the economy to be where it is now; to be where they are enjoying now. Mr Speaker, the Government is spending.

The Government has been given GHC293 billion Appropriation. We are paying GHC76.2 billion for compensation. Are we not paying Ghanaians? Has anybody come out to say that we are not paying them? [Some Hon Members: No!]

We are spending. Goods and Services, GHC6.7 billion. Go and check the Appropriation Act. I am quoting from the Appropriation Act. GHC6.7 billion. Grants and other government obligations, GHC55 billion. We are spending. Coupled with GHC32 billion Capital Expenditure. Mr Speaker, in all, they should go to the Controller and Accountant General's Department and check this. The Government has paid GHC114.5 billion. The Government released money from the Controller and Accountant General's Department.

Mr Speaker, let me be a bit detailed. We have paid Eurobond obligations, Domestic bondholders, District Assemblies Common Fund (DAFCF), Social Security and National Insurance Trust (SSNIT). They should go and check the Energy sector and the Ghana Education Trust Fund (GETFund). We have given money to them. Payment of arrears, Free Senior High School, National Health Insurance Scheme. They should listen to more. Vaccines and Essential Medicine payment, Capitation Grant, Beneficiaries, School Feeding Programmes, BECE registration, No-Fees-Stress policy. Go to the Schools.

The Teacher training allowance has been paid. Nursing allowance, we have paid. Assembly Member's allowance, we have paid. National Apprenticeship

Programme, we have paid. Adumawura, we have paid. Recapitalisation of NIB, we have paid.

Mr Speaker, in all GH¢84.2 billion in interest payments. This is the state of the Ghanaian economy. They know where they left this country in terms of the economy. They know where, within the last six months, we have brought the economy to.

Mr Speaker, to conclude, this economy has been rated by Fitch, an International Rating Organisation, from restricted defaults to B+. It is remarkable, please. Now, the Government is doing well in terms of exports. We are reducing imports. The Minister said we are reducing import duties. Import duties have been reduced. He quoted a figure. What is the reason? Because we are implementing programmes that would boost exports and reduce imports.

Mr Speaker, NDC will never make any transfer payments. Transfer payment means one pays for something for no work done. Unlike their Government, they should go and check Crow and Associates, they paid US\$1 million for no work done. US\$58 million for the National Cathedral. Mr Speaker, Sky train. How much was it? US\$2 million. We will not do transfer payment.

Mr Speaker, as of last week, when the Mid-Year Budget Review was read, we heard in this Chamber that we have a scandal of almost GH¢150.4 million from the Controller between 2023 and 2024. What happened? Please—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, conclude.

Dr Afful: Let us rise up to support this Government because we have started very well. Only six months and look at the achievement. What about if we chalk one, two, three and four years? What will happen?

Mr Speaker, let me thank you so much for the opportunity. We promise the people that the NDC Government has come to stay. The NDC Government has come to perform. The NDC Government has come to redeem this country from the NPP. Thank you so much. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, it is now the turn of Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah. 15 minutes.

Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah (NPP — Ofoase-Ayirebi): Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity to contribute to the Motion currently before the House to approve the Mid-Year Review of the Budget and Economic Policy for the 2025 Financial Year.

Mr Speaker, I know that a lot of people will be expecting at a time like this that our Colleagues on the other Side will say everything that has happened so far is good. And then those on this Side will be saying everything that has happened is bad. But Mr Speaker, you see, on this Side, we are very patriotic. So, where we have to give commendation, we will give commendation. Where we have to give critique, we will give the necessary critique; where we have to draw their attention to some things, we will do so

and then, where we have to caution them, we will do so.

7.12 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I will be speaking on only four matters. First are observations that are worthy of commendation. If we look at the fiscal programme that the Minister for Finance presented to us earlier this year, and look at the critique that we gave as a Side of the House, and then we look at the returns that he has brought to us in the Mid-Year Review, I will commend him for listening. Let me show the House—When the Minister came to the House, he came with a fiscal programme. He said he was going to raise revenue of GHC102 billion without introducing new taxes. Let no soul say he was not here on that day. We all recall when he said he was going to increase tax to Gross Domestic Product (GDP) ratio from 13 to 18 per cent without introducing new taxes. I remember us drawing his attention to the fact that that was not possible. In fact, he told us that, despite the removal of taxes which he was promising, the way he was going to close the GHC6 billion gap was that, he was going to reduce Value Added Tax (VAT) retention threshold from 6 per cent to 4 per cent and that would close the gap. I am sure we all remember. The outturns have come and now we are beginning to realise that the Minister's revenue strategy, originally as he presented, has failed. Remember that the Minister clawed back about GHC11 billion swept from 31st December and then has introduced eight new taxes to try to close that gap.

Mr Speaker, despite that, the evidence that his strategy has failed is that, revenue has underperformed by GHC3 billion. But where I commend him is that, on the expenditure side, contrary to the programme he brought to us, that he was going to spend 128 billion, because of the critique that it is important to cut about 3 per cent of GDP. We recall when we said 3 per cent of GDP, about GHC30 billion has to be cut; he has now gone and has cut. If we look at the numbers he is presented to us, half year he has cut GHC19 billion and if we model to the end of the year, by the end of the year, that 30 billion that we are saying is what needs to be cut is where he will be heading to and so I commend him for listening.

Mr Speaker, but I will show him where the problem still is. We want to also draw his attention to the currency. If we look at what they are doing on the currency, today the currency has appreciated by about 42 per cent. That is a matter of fact. Why? Among other things is the fact that we are backing our currency with gold. I recall the Deputy Majority Leader, Mr Ricketts-Hagan, on his feet here, admitting that one of the major reasons for which our currency has appreciated is because we are backing it with gold.

Mr Speaker, the Gold Purchase Programme, which is one of the major contributors to where we are today, was launched on the 17th of June, 2021. So, I commend the Government for continuing with the Gold Purchase Programme. The Gold Purchase Programme was being done by the Bank of Ghana and the Precious Mineral Marketing Company

(PMMC). The Bank of Ghana is still here. The PMMC is what they have rebranded as Gold Board. So, I give them commendation for continuing the Gold Purchase Programme. It was the Gold Purchase Programme that moved us from 8.7 tonnes of gold to 30 tonnes of gold when we started.

The third commendation I will give is for continuing with the Inflation Reduction Programme. Remember that when the international crisis hit us, inflation went as high as 54 per cent and then the Central Bank started the tight monetary policy aimed at bringing us down. That was what brought inflation down from 54 per cent to 23 per cent by the time we were leaving power and as they came, they are continuing. So, the first part of my submission is to commend them for continuing the Gold Purchase Programme, continuing the Inflation Reduction Programme, and continuing or following the fiscal critique that we gave.

Mr Speaker, but when we say this Government is not spending, sometimes they confuse it for fiscal discipline. I heard the Chairman of the Committee on Economy and Development, my very good Friend, Dr Afful, suggesting that what is happening is fiscal discipline. Hon Chairman, it is not. There is a difference between fiscal discipline and a failure to meet fiscal targets. When they programmed that they were going to raise GHC102 billion and that they will spend GHC128 billion and achieve a primary balance of 0.4 per cent, fiscal discipline is when one is able to do that. When they fail to raise the revenue and fail to spend, that is not fiscal discipline. Because they

are not raising the revenues that are required so that they can spend, this is fiscal failure. The consequence is that they are failing to deliver on some essential public goods and services. When one fails on fiscal policy or fiscal programme, it will hit them in the goods and services and it will hit them in development. My Brother, the Minister, is asking me, “such as?” I will show him.

One of the public goods and services, Dr Murtala, is security. He asked me and I am responding to him. To be able to provide security, one has to release money, so that the intelligence agencies can gather intelligence and act on it. When they fail to meet the fiscal programme, they cannot even pay the allowances for intelligence officers. I regret to say this, but because Dr Murtala asked, that is why I am telling him. When people plan that they are going to Nalerigu Senior High School to commit murder, the intelligence agencies cannot pick it up because they are not spending. When a government is not releasing the funds for intelligence work to be done, when people are plotting insecurity, the intelligence system cannot pick it up.

Dr Murtala asked me about examples of the public goods and services that will suffer. Let me give him some more examples. Take the flagship programmes. The Government said it was going to do a National Apprenticeship Programme. So far, because of the fiscal failure, they have only been able to release 7 per cent of the Budget. Because of the fiscal failure, they have released zero per cent of the budget for the One Million Coders Programme. Because of the fiscal failure, they have

released zero per cent of the Budget for the Agriculture for Economic Transformation Agenda. They have released zero per cent of the Budget for the Women's Development Bank. They have released zero per cent of the Budget for the Big Push Programme, and they are still listing old projects that have been commissioned. So, I am drawing their attention to the fact that, because they misconceived the fiscal programme, it is showing where they have to release money and they cannot keep going on failing to release money. Because if they do not release the money, public goods and services and development will struggle. People are looking for hospitals in their constituencies, but because of fiscal failure, they have not been able to add one cement block to Agenda 111. Why? Because they are not raising and spending. How often can they tell people who are not getting the public goods and services that they promised, that what they have done is that they brought the primary balance to 1.1? It is like a father who says that he is piling up all his salary in his bank account, but he will not pay his children's school fees and medical bills. When they ask him, he will say the bank account is looking nice. That is what is going on and that is why we are drawing their attention to the fact, though we have commended them in some areas, that they cannot continue like this.

Mr Speaker, there are some recommendations we want to make. These are recommendations about some things that must be sustained. So, for example, let me speak about the currency. Now the International Monetary Fund (IMF) has exposed them that part of what

they are doing on the currency front is that they are dumping about US\$1.5 billion from the reserves that we left them onto the market to suppress the currency. They have advised them that they should desist from that. The question is, how do they sustain an appreciation of the currency? We have already come to an understanding of why the currency is appreciated and what they are even doing as part of it. But how do they sustain it?

Mr Speaker, I have said that we are patriotic. We are not like those who would prevent them from laying Papers on the Floor or laying Bills or fighting on the Floor for political advantage. We will give them feedback and advice where necessary.

Mr Speaker, for example, on the currency front, what the Government should do is to take a lot more seriously, the whole exercise of ensuring that exporters retire the forex earnings, properly so-called, back into the jurisdiction. The Letter of Commitment (LoC) requirements are what they should pay attention to.

7.22 p.m.

If they do not do that and they do an artificial dumping—Today, gold prices are high, so they are benefiting, what will happen when tomorrow gold prices are not high? Will they have US\$1.4 billion every six months to be dumping onto the market? No, so, Hon Minister, in all humility, your Brothers and Sisters on this Side mentioned to you that, to sustain the currency gains, pay more attention to the proper retirement of foreign exchange earnings and not an artificial dumping.

Because, today, if they dump currency artificially on the market and they suppress the rates, Governor Asiamah will have the rates, but *Abokyi* will have the dollar. Today, a lot of importers are complaining that even when they file paperwork at the banks for transfer of forex, for three to four weeks, they do not get it. So, if they go ahead with this artificial dumping and suppression, what will happen is that Governor Asiamah, as I told you, will have the rate, *Abokyi* will have the dollar.

Mr Speaker, on the revenue measures, our recommendation is that some of the revenue measures he has introduced would, in the long run, take inflation up. We said it when they introduced the *Dumsor* Levy at midnight after they waited for everybody to go to bed. We told them that extra levies on petroleum would, eventually, translate into inflation. For us, they said because we do not have goodwill, we should keep quiet. If they like, they should not listen to us. Their own Governor Asiamah is drawing their attention to the fact that it is a risk for increased inflation in the medium term. So, our advice is that some of these panic revenue measures—They originally misconceived the fiscal programme and they are now panicking and have introduced eight new taxes. Some of them, like the *Dumsor* Levy and the Special Import Levy, would translate into inflation at some point in time. It will be good for them to pull them back now, at this point in time, and rather look at what they can do on the expenditure side to cut.

And speaking of expenditure cuts, if there is a place where the 24-Hour

Economy is needed the most now, it is the Public Investment Division at the Ministry of Finance. Why? Because that is where public-private partnerships are conceptualised. That is where they need to be working around the clock, so that they can crowd in private funding to support what they cannot fund from the Treasury. So, their Brothers and Sisters on this Side will give them the feedback to pay attention to these things.

I would end with a caution. Mr Speaker, the cost of government services would go up because fees and charges are being put up by about 30 to 40 per cent. Electricity is going up by about 16 per cent, in addition to the eight new taxes, so the Government should take caution that the measures would increase the cost of government services, eventually the cost of doing business, and the cost of living because of inflation.

Finally, we also ask them to tone down on the propaganda. The list that the Minister for Finance brought—Now, people on social media are drawing his attention to the fact that that is not the price of Yazz sanitary pad. People are drawing his attention to what he came to list here—*[Interruption]*—The Minister came here and claimed that there was no Gold for Oil Programme. The Bank of Ghana concedes that there was a gold for—In fact if there was no Gold for Oil Programme, why did they make the announcement that they have cancelled the Gold for Oil Programme? They should that propaganda. For example, a good chunk of the road project they have listed are a repackage of already existing

road projects. They do not need that propaganda to try and create effect.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, conclude.

Mr Nkrumah: Mr Speaker, I will conclude by saying that we will commend them where commendation is due, but we will also give them critique in good faith. If they take it and adjust, it will help all of us. The propaganda is too much. For now, because they listened, they are beginning to adjust fiscal programme, but it is not sustainable. If they adopt the advice that we are giving them, the Republic will be the better for it.

I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Minister for Environment, Science and Technology (Dr Muhammed Murtala Ibrahim) (MP): Thank you, Mr Speaker for giving me the opportunity to contribute to the Mid-Year Budget Review as presented by the Hon Minister for Finance.

Mr Speaker, government is a continuum and I agree with my very good Friend, Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah, in admonishing us to continue with some of the things he claims they did. I do think that if you are really a patriot and a democrat, there is nothing wrong with even continuing with things that the previous Administration did. But one thing, Mr Speaker, he failed to acknowledge is that, at least, we did not continue with the corruption; we did not. And I thought he would have commended

this Government for not continuing with the outright corruption that, indeed, affected the people of this country.

Mr Speaker, we can stand here and speak the big English. We can stand here and use all the economic jargons, but that is not of interest to the man who is struggling to look for job opportunities, my grandmother who sells *koko* in the village and the woman who sells *kelewele* in the constituency of Kojo Oppong Nkrumah. What is of interest to the ordinary Ghanaian is how they feel and, as a young student leader, I remember, in 2000, President Kufuor, then candidate Kufuor, he said, “*Hwe w’asetena mu na to aba pa*” – pardon me with my wobbling Twi; at least, two years in Kwame Nkrumah University of Science and Technology, Kumasi (KNUST), I am trying to manage – that is of interest to the people of this country. The people of this country are well aware that the cedi has come down and my Brother was being pessimistic that what he should be thinking of is sustaining it.

Mr Speaker, I want to ask a simple question and this question may be regarded as a rhetorical question: is it that he is uncomfortable that the cedi has actually arrested the fugitive of a dollar? We were told in this country that the dollar was arrested, locked at the Police Headquarters and the keys were actually given to the Inspector General of Police (IGP). In fact, the dollar was a fugitive. It is not fluke and it is not just by accident that we have been able to reduce and, in

fact, arrested the fugitive dollar under their watch.

Mr Speaker, he said that we are not spending and I was shocked that he was without empathy to the life that was lost. He made reference to the fact that our security agencies could not detect that there would be some killing. Unfortunately — and I know he is my good Friend – the difference is that, with all the resources they had, they could not realise that Ahmed Suale, a journalist in this country, was going to be murdered in the most barbarous manner that he was murdered. The security agencies could not do so. In fact, he talked about the dollar and gold and I asked myself whether we just discovered gold. If he is not being pretentious and told us that the NDC is continuing with some of the so-called good works, where were they? Did they not have the good works? When they won the elections at the back of competence, that was what they told the people of this country: that they had the men and with all these men and gold, they could not do what the NDC has done in less than a year.

It is shocking, Mr Speaker, that he is telling us that but for the challenges they encountered—Let me remind my Hon Friend, the Russia-Ukraine war is more profound and escalatory than it was—[**An Hon Member:** *Wo boa!*]
—We were told that every problem we had in this country was as a result of the unfortunate incident. And he, Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah, was an active participant in the mess they created because he was a Minister of State; he was not sitting on the fence. And

I think that the least he could do was to tell this Government, it is doing so well and they are praying—And I expect him to join me tomorrow, so that we can have some prayer before we come into the Chamber. Let us pray that the cedi which is doing so well—And in fact, I engage people who are engaged in import and export and they are telling us that they are doing so well because of the value of the cedi.

But to say that what we should be thinking of is how we sustain it, I thought that he would commend us for even achieving that and be praying that it should be sustained.

7.32 p.m.

I can assure them that the sustainability is something that is real; it is not a fluke. It is very clear to everybody.

Mr Speaker, food inflation was even the most disastrous challenge facing the people of this country. Fuel prices was and I think that if we want to have an analysis and juxtapose between what they promised the people of this country and what we inherited, it is very clear “feeli feeli, feeli gadochi” that the people of this country, indeed, were in excruciating unacceptable economic circumstances, occasioned by not just incompetence, but gross, crass and unacceptable incompetence they subjected the people of this country to.

When it comes to what we are achieving today, the ordinary man walking on the street, the people in my

constituency in Tamale Central and the constituency of my Hon Friend are not interested in those jargons. They are not interested in the excellent grammar that we speak. They are interested in their livelihood and in the circumstances.

Now, in this country, when they introduced the National Youth Employment Programme (NYEP) and Nation Builders Corps (NABCO), we warned them. We told them that it was not sustainable. It is very clear to everybody that the reason we had a huge unemployment rate in this country, particularly youth unemployment, was because that particular policy intervention was nothing but a policy intervention that was emotionally driven.

The NYEP started under President Kufuor, under NPP, then we had President Nana Addo. The least he could do was to continue with the NYEP and try to find solutions to some of the teething challenges; he never did that. He felt that he needed to have something that is completely different, so it was egoistic and that is the reason unemployment, which we inherited under their watch at around 17 per cent, by the time, indeed, they left office, what was the unemployment rate?

NDC left it at 8.6 per cent; they left youth unemployment at a level over 13 per cent, totalled at 14 per cent, so unemployment was huge. He said that inflation was around 54 per cent because of international challenges. What were they? They were Russia-Ukraine war and

perhaps, the death of the Queen was also one of the contributory factors for which reason this country went through what we went through.

I just want to tell the people who are watching us that they have seen the difference. Even with the successes we have chalked, the NDC has not gone to town parading and telling people what we have done. We allow our work to speak for itself. We allow the interventions we have made to demonstrate it and for the people of this country to feel it in their pockets. If it was the Minority, they would have gone to town wanting everybody to hear it.

Mr Speaker, let me conclude with this proverb—*[Interruption]*—I have a lot of time, Mr Speaker. Mr Speaker, there is a popular proverb, which is very simple, and I expect my Brother, Alhaji Habib Iddrisu, to know and apologies to those who may be taking their meals. That is, when one sleeps with an itching anus, he wakes up with smelling fingers. The reason they are finding it extremely difficult to defend their record is because of what they have occasioned.

And he, my good Friend, Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah, was an active participant in the mess that was created. A mess which we are still trying to clean and in fact, with what we are doing now, we have not even applied the second gear, it is just the first gear and that is intended to clean the mess that was created. By the time we finish and get to the second and third gears, the people of this country will

say, bye-bye to our good Friends in the NPP.

But let me also state, Mr Speaker, that in terms of governance, if we read the 2017 Financial Statement, and I urge my Brother and others to go and read that, in every single paragraph of that Statement, they talked about corruption and how they were going to fight it. By the time we had the Mid-Year Budget Review for 2017, they started removing the word “corruption” from the Financial Statement. By the time we had the 2020 Budget Statement, the word “corruption” was mentioned only once because instead of fighting corruption, they were fighting anybody who was fighting corruption.

That is the reason for everything we do in this country; what is significant is our ability to fight corruption. For the purposes of those who do not know, at any point in time there is a change in government, either through the ballot or through the bullet in our history, corruption has always been used as a justification for the changes we have experienced in this country. Therefore, corruption plays a significant role.

They won the elections in 2017 at the back of corruption. In fact, what they did was not even propaganda, it was outright lies. They said President Mahama and his wife had hotels in Dubai and all manner of things and their communicators went to town with it. Not a scintilla of evidence were they able to provide, but if one mentions the NPP in this country, everybody, even a two-year-old child, would associate it with what? Corruption.

If one mentions the NPP to anybody who is not even in this country, they would associate it with what? With corruption. To the extent that they have communicators of NPP who, indeed, have all gone on radio and there are evidences that one of the reasons they are struggling is because there was an unacceptable level of corruption in the administration of the NPP.

So, Mr Speaker, I am saying that whatever good thing we do and whatever policy intervention we have had, what is significant in determining the success of that particular policy intervention is our ability to fight this monster called corruption. But the difference between the NDC and the NPP is very clear. The difference between President Mahama and President Nana Addo is very clear. Whereas President Mahama did everything to fight corruption and is still fighting it, as a matter of fact, unfortunately, what we have experienced under NPP is what we call—*[Interruption]*—Unfortunately, the Flagstaff House became a citadel for corruption. To the extent—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please, you are supposed to address the Chair.

Dr Ibrahim: Mr Speaker, to the extent that one of the aspirants to lead their party said that people took bribes to grant access to His Excellency the President. These are not my words, but the words of one of the leading members of their party; someone who wanted to be elected as a flag bearer and possibly, hoping to be elected as the President of the Republic of Ghana. He said that for a

person to have access to the President, one needed to pay US\$20,000. Is that not worrying? Is that not shocking?

And to be very honest, Mr Speaker, the courage of our Friends across the aisle is just tremendous. No one would even expect that they would have the audacity to even make a statement. Yet, with the mess that is created, with the mess that everybody in this country agrees to that they created for the people of this country, they have the audacity to even tell us that we do not know how to govern. I wish they could lend me a scintilla of their audacity and courage because it takes a courageous person to be able to talk about the governance of this country, considering what they have created. It takes someone with a level of courage to be able to debate on the issue of how we have managed the cedi against the dollar. It takes someone with courage to be able to tell us that even fertiliser, which was meant for farmers and had written on it “not for sale”, they sold those fertilisers to the farmers of this country.

Now, if they are telling us, it is because of the Gold Board that the economy is doing well, did they not have gold under their Administration? As a matter of fact, at a time, when leading members of their party who told them that there were some Ministers who were not doing well and those Ministers should be booted out, they all cowed to submission. Today, they are talking about that.

Mr Speaker, the least said about patriotism the better. Now my Brother is telling us that they are patriots and that is why they are supporting and have never

been against any of such intervention. As a matter of fact, they have staged more walk outs in this Parliament than their total number in Parliament. Patriotic citizens do not walk out; they argue with reason.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, conclude.

Dr Ibrahim: Patriotic citizens do not just hold press conferences. In fact, I am told that their other name is “press conferences”.

So, Mr Speaker, it is very clear that the NDC, under President Mahama, the Minister for Finance and his able Deputy, have showed our Friends—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Time is up. [*Hear! Hear!*] I will give the floor to Gideon Boaku. Deputy Ranking Member, you have ten minutes.

Dr Gideon Boako (NPP—Tano North): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the discussions on the Mid-Year Budget Review as presented by the Minister for Finance.

7.42 p.m.

Mr Speaker, just like all other previous Mid-Year Budget Reviews, this Budget does not seek for new approvals for appropriation. So, I get a sense that the prevailing headwinds in the global and domestic economy have been very charitable to Government and therefore the Minister is not seeking to alter the macro fiscal targets that were set in the March Budget.

Mr Speaker, before I continue, it is important that since this is a House of records, every information that is put out is checked. And I would do so to the presentation the Minister for Finance made. But before then, I want to speak to something that the speaker who just spoke talked about.

Mr Speaker, I do not know whether it is a natural occurrence or some blood plasma moving through the veins of my Colleagues on the other Side to do propaganda with everything. He talked about the fact that the unemployment rate increased under the period of the NPP to somewhere around 14 per cent and I am wondering where he got those figures from. Mr Speaker, I have data with me from Statista and Fitch Solutions and they put the overall unemployment rate for 2024 at 4 per cent. The youth unemployment rate aged between 15 to 24 at 5.41 per cent. In 2016, this figure was 5.23 per cent, a reduction. Mr Speaker, it is surprising that our Colleagues will be talking about data that cannot be found anywhere. The propaganda is too much and it is important that we desist from that.

Mr Speaker, listening to the Minister for Finance, I got a bit worried. Worried in the sense that the Minister for Finance should be clothed with accurate data and should not come to this House to mislead us and the public. Mr Speaker, the Minister for Finance in this document indicated that this Government had recorded primary surplus and that is the first time that Ghana had recorded that. Mr Speaker, with all due respect, that is not true. In fact, in 2017, 2018 and 2019,

Ghana recorded primary surplus in this country. So, it cannot be true that a Minister for Finance would say that what has been recorded this year is the first one. In fact, the surplus that was recorded in 2017 was the first time Ghana was recording such surplus in 15 years. So, if there is anything to talk about record, it is the record in 2017, 2018, 2019. As far as our primary surplus is concerned, that was an unprecedented record.

Mr Speaker, again, the Minister claims in paragraph 183 of this document that for the first time in the history of Ghana, Ghana recorded a negative 15.6 rate of debt accumulation and said that they have been able to reduce the public debt by GH¢103.7 billion. Mr Speaker, while this is true, it cannot be true that this is the first time that Ghana is recording a negative debt accumulation. Mr Speaker, let me put the data very close to their doorstep. In 2022, between November and December, Ghana's debt stock reduced from GH¢382.7 billion to GH¢240.9 billion, a reduction of GH¢141 billion under the previous NPP Government. So, it cannot be true that this is the first time Ghana is having negative debt accumulation. In fact, the December 2022 figure was 37 per cent negative debt accumulation. So, it is important that the Minister gets the facts right.

Mr Speaker, I will advise that the Minister shows some level of humility when he is presenting to this House and not go around bandying figures around. The Minister in paragraph 184 of this Budget also talks about a debt-to-GDP ratio reduction. Mr Speaker, I know on

account of the rebasing, this will go down. But what the Minister said, that this reduction is unprecedented and is coming on the back of ingenuity by this Government, cannot be true. Rather, it is important that the Minister recognises the role that was played by the previous Government and give credit where it is due. What accounted for the debt reduction?

Mr Speaker, first, is the debt relief under the debt restructuring programme instituted by the previous Government. And the former Minister for Finance talked about the billions of cedis that were relieved. Recently, we got €87.7 million debt relief from France.

Again, Mr Speaker, the reduction is coming on the back of the appreciation of the cedi, which is due to the strong external reserves built over the years by the previous Government. This gave the Government the room to inject dollars into the economy. Even though they denied, the IMF has exposed them that they injected about US\$1.5 billion into the economy.

Mr Speaker, again, the GDP expansion under the previous Government, which raised the denominator and helped ease the debt ratio, is what is accounting for the reduction in the debt. And we have seen higher GDP growth of 4.9 per cent in the first quarter of 2024 to 5.3 per cent in first quarter of 2025. Mr Speaker, when all of this happens, one is naturally able to have reduction in their debt, not necessarily because one has instituted any programme that is doing that.

Mr Speaker, again, the claim by the Minister for Finance that the Government has been able to reverse the cedi depreciation to the 2022 level is also false. Mr Speaker, the Minister for Finance claims in his presentation that the cedi to the dollar rate was GHC17. Mr Speaker, this is a lie and can never be true—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, withdraw the word “lie”.

Dr Boako: Mr Speaker, with all due respect, I withdraw. There has never been any period in this country during the eight years of the NPP government where the Bank of Ghana recorded a cedi to dollar rate of GHC17. I am surprised that the Minister for Finance will lower himself to that level and present that figure to us. Mr Speaker, what was left to this Government in January was 14.7 per cent. Mr Speaker, to use the Minister for Finance’s own data to refute what he said, he says that as of the end of June 2025, the cedi’s appreciation was 42.6 per cent. Mr Speaker, if indeed they inherited a cedi to dollar rate of 17 per cent, the appreciation would have been more than 42 per cent. In fact, it would have been somewhere 60 per cent. So, technically, that is not true. The mathematics does not add up. Statistically, it does not add up.

Mr Speaker, the exchange rate stability is crucial to the economy and it is important that we record exchange rate appreciation. Mr Speaker, I must say that there are two fundamental features about any currency. These are the rate of exchange of the currency with respect to other trading partners as well as the

purchasing power of the currency. Mr Speaker, the true value of a currency does not lie in its rate of exchange, but the purchasing power of that currency. Yes, we have stability, but what is the purchasing power of the cedi today? Mr Speaker, cement price in January 2025 was GH¢90. As of April, it was GH¢130. **[Some Majority Members: Eii!!]** Mr Speaker, Sure deodorant in January was GH¢35, today, it is GH¢45. Mr Speaker, standard loaf of bread was GH¢18 in January. Today, it is GH¢23. Mr Speaker, bottled water was GH¢28 in January—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, conclude.

Dr Boako: Today, it is GH¢36.

Mr Speaker, I am talking about the purchasing power of the cedi today. What is the purchasing power of the cedi today? Today, the cedi cannot do anything meaningful on the market. On top of that, we have increased prices for the average Ghanaian.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I rest my case here. Thank you so much. *[Hear! Hear!]*

7.52 p.m.

Second Deputy Majority Whip (Mr Richard Acheampong): Mr Speaker, we have done 4 – 4. So, we want to go to the Order Paper *Addendum 2* to lay some papers. After that the two debaters will come and conclude the debate.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Hon Members, the Order Paper Addendum 2, At Commencement of Public Business, the item numbered 1, presentation of Papers.

Chairman of the Committee Responsible for Gender, Children and Social Protection?

PAPERS

By the Chairman of the Committee—

(i) Report of the Committee on Gender, Children and Social Welfare on the determination of the urgency of the Social Protection Bill, 2025.

(ii) Report of the Committee on Gender, Children and Social Welfare on the Social Protection Bill, 2025.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, we will go back to the original Order Paper and continue with the debate. So, we now have 2-2 from each Side.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. It is now the turn of Hon Felix Kwakye Ofose. You have 15 minutes.

MOTION

Mid-Year Budget Review, 2025

[Resumption of Debate from Column 117]

Minister for Government Communication (Mr Felix Kwakye Ofose) (MP): Thank you very much, Mr

Speaker, for your generous allocation of time.

Mr Speaker, I know that our Colleagues on the other Side are always rankled when we recall the abysmal depths from which we have pulled this economy. Mr Speaker, I would even have thought that this would be a monologue and not a debate. It is for two reasons. The first is that they fled the Budget presentation. So, I wonder exactly what they are debating. And then, Mr Speaker, given their abysmal performance, they should have refrained from further commentary on the Ghanaian economy. So, this should really have been a monologue. But be that as it may, Mr Speaker, there is a reason economic performance is measured by objective indicators which are not subject to opinion.

Mr Speaker, there can be no honest assessment of the Ghanaian economy today that can lead to a conclusion that things are not far better today than they were at the beginning of this year when we took over the reins of power. Mr Speaker, the Mid-Year Policy Review that the Minister for Finance presented is the very best we have had in the history of Ghana. *[Hear! Hear!]* Mr Speaker, I used to hold the view that the economic performance of the Mills administration was the best we have seen in this country's history until the Minister for Finance showed up to present the Mid-Year Budget Policy Review.

Mr Speaker, with your indulgence, I will run through a few of the metrics that are used to assess the health of an

economy and show beyond doubt that the period we are in is the very best we have seen. Mr Speaker, we are currently under an International Monetary Fund (IMF) programme courtesy the mismanagement of our Colleagues on the other Side. When they went into the IMF programme, they agreed that the most critical indicator that would be used to assess their performance and management of the economy would be the primary balance. They themselves agreed that it is the main anchor of the IMF programme. Mr Speaker, the primary balance is nothing more than a measure of the difference between revenue and expenditure minus interest payments or debt servicing. It simply means that if you had not serviced your debts, which can be a statutory obligation, where would you be in terms of the management of your finances with respect to your revenue and expenditure?

Mr Speaker, when we took over power, the primary balance on commitment basis was at negative 3.9 per cent, which was a deficit. It means that if you subtract expenditure from revenue and take out debt servicing or interest payments, we ran a negative of 3.9 per cent. Mr Speaker, when the Hon Minister for Finance came here, he said that this year, or by half year, we had projected to achieve a primary surplus of 0.4 per cent. Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister for Finance reported that we have in fact exceeded that and done a primary surplus of 1.1 per cent. It simply means that we spent less than we earned. And every analyst of any economy will tell you that if it turns out that a country spends less than it earns, then they are on the right path as far as prudence is concerned.

Mr Speaker, if you look at the fiscal deficit itself, which is a straightforward measure of expenditure minus revenue, it was 0.7 per cent by mid-year. What is interesting is that the Hon Minister for Finance projected in his 2025 Budget that we would do 1.8 per cent. And for clarity, the larger your deficit, the worse it is for the economy. And the smaller the deficit, the better it is for the economy. So, if we said we would do a deficit of 1.8 per cent and today we have done 0.7 per cent, it means that we have done far better than we even imagined and that is to the credit of this Government.

Mr Speaker, our Colleagues on the other Side are making a song and dance out of the exchange rates. I would have thought that they would refrain from even commenting on the exchange rates because their handling of the exchange rates is the most catastrophic in our history. Mr Speaker, my Colleague who just spoke before me was contending that the cedi never got to 17 cedis against a dollar under their tenure. Mr Speaker, in November 2022, the Ghana cedis exchanged for 17 cedis to a dollar and it is a fact on the forex markets. In fact, by the time they left office, the cedi was almost at 17 cedis to a dollar on the forex markets.

Mr Speaker, Hon Minister for Finance has reported that the cedi appreciated by 42 per cent against the US dollar. It appreciated by 30.3 per cent against the British pound and appreciated by 25.6 per cent against the euro. Mr Speaker, the appreciation of the cedi in the last six months is the very best we have had in the history of Ghana. In fact, the only one that

comes close was the 38 per cent appreciation in 1997 under the Rawlings administration.

Mr Speaker, inflation simply measures the rate at which the prices of goods increase on the markets. And because we do year-on-year inflation calculation in Ghana, it simply measures the rate at which the price of goods are increasing on the markets at the point one is doing the analysis against the same point in the preceding year. When we took over power, inflation was 23.8 per cent. Mr Speaker, today it is 13.7 per cent.

Mr Speaker, with growth, the Hon Minister for Finance said in the Budget, or, I beg your pardon, the NPP achieved a 4.9 per cent growth around the same time last year. Mr Speaker, today we have achieved 5.3 per cent growth, which is much better than what they left. Mr Speaker, our debt-to-GDP ratio, which simply assesses whether or not theoretically we can pay off our debts in one bullet payment with the size of our GDP, shows that today our debt-to-GDP ratio is 43.8 per cent of GDP. It simply means that if we pick our debts and compare it to our GDP, we have an extra 56.2 per cent to spare if we were to do one bullet payment with our GDP. But the curious thing about this is that when our Colleagues on the other Side entered the IMF programme, they agreed that we will move from the 104 per cent debt-to-GDP ratio, the disaster that they recorded sometime in 2023, to 45 per cent in 2034. So, the target was that we were going to manage our debts such that by 2034, we achieve a debt-to-GDP ratio of 45 per cent.

8.02 p.m.

Mr Speaker, as I speak to you, nine clear years before the target, we have achieved 43.8 per cent. [*Hear! Hear!*] In six months, we have achieved what they had projected to get in almost a decade. It is a remarkable achievement that nobody can run away from.

Mr Speaker, I also see that our Colleagues are refusing to acknowledge the tremendous improvements we have made in our reserves. Our reserves currently stand at US\$11.12 billion as of June 2025. That gives us 4.8 months of import cover. Mr Speaker, we inherited US\$8.9 billion under them, which gave us barely four months import cover.

Now, Mr Speaker, they say that the International Monetary Fund (IMF) says we are pumping dollars into the system to safeguard our currency. Mr Speaker, forget about the fact that there are similar IMF reports that show that they were spending US\$2.4 billion or they were pumping US\$2.4 billion around the same period in 2023-2024 in order to protect the currency. Yet the currency reached about GH¢16.00 to a dollar on the foreign market.

Mr Speaker, what is remarkable is that under the IMF Programme that they entered and we inherited, the target was that within the first six months of this year, we would increase our reserves by US\$498 million. Mr Speaker, through the remarkable performance of the Minister for Finance under President John Dramani Mahama, we have exceeded this and in fact, increased our reserves by

US\$1.6 billion over the same period. What it means is that we have crossed the threshold that the IMF set for us. We have done far better than we thought. Indeed, we have performed three times better than we had imagined. Therefore, if it becomes necessary to make forex available on the markets, any responsible central bank will do so in order to protect the currency, because we have all seen the benefits that have accrued from the appreciation of the cedi. It has led to indisputable reductions in the prices of goods and services on the market, contrary to the claims that our opponents are making.

At the very least, Mr Speaker, fuel prices have dropped eight consecutive times between January and now. When we took over power, fuel was selling in some Shell filling stations for GH¢15.00 a litre. Today, the same commodity sells under GH¢12.00 a litre in some filling stations.

Mr Speaker, if we go onto the market today and do a cursory price survey, we will see significant reductions in the price of goods and services.

Mr Speaker, a tonne of iron rods, at the beginning of this year, under the NPP, sold for GH¢9,400.00. Today, the same thing sells for GH¢7,500.00, which is a reduction of almost GH¢2,000.00.

Mr Speaker, Dettol Antiseptic, 500 millilitres, used to sell for GH¢85.00; today, it sells for GH¢65.00. Mr Speaker, Yazz sanitary pad sells for GH¢15.00 today. When we took over power in

January, it sold for GH¢25.00. Indeed, there are shops that sell it for GH¢13.00. Mr Speaker, a bucket of onions was selling for GH¢120.00 under the NPP; as of July, this month, it sells for GH¢95.00 under President Mahama. Mr Speaker, a sack of maize was selling for GH¢1,600.00. Today, it sells for GH¢1,400.00. A sack of *kokonte*, one of the delicacies of many Ghanaians, used to sell for GH¢1,200.00. Today, it sells for GH¢950 a sack. A 5kg bag of rice used to sell for GH¢135.00. Today, it sells for GH¢95.00, which is a saving of GH¢40. Mr Speaker, there are other sacks of rice. Millicent rice, for instance, GH¢125.00 under the NPP. Today, it sells for GH¢95.00. 2.2 kg of Tasty Tom tomato paste used to sell for GH¢80.00. Today, it sells for GH¢50.00, which is a reduction of GH¢30.00. I could go on and on.

There is no dispute that the cost of living today is lower than it was under the NPP, and the reason is that we have managed the exchange rate such that these items that are mostly imported are now cheaper when they get into Ghana than they were under them.

Mr Speaker, there was also talk about what has accounted for the reduction in our public debts. I recall that when we were in opposition and we took issue with the rapid accumulation of debts under the NPP, one of the reasons they ascribed was that there had been a sharp depreciation of the currency, the cedi, and therefore, the external component of our debts had gone up, resulting in the increase. One of

the key proponents of that was the Hon Oppong Nkrumah, who was the Chief Spokesperson of Government. If today, the exchange rate has been managed better by Hon Ato Forson, the Governor of the Central Bank, and President Mahama, and it has resulted in a drastic reduction in our debts, it is something that this Government must be credited for.

Mr Speaker, they also say that there was a Gold Purchase Programme, and therefore, that should be credited for the appreciation of the cedi. They accumulated gold from 2021 to 2024, and yet their currency went to GH¢17.00. Mr Speaker, between January and now, US\$5.1 billion —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up. I will now give the floor to Hon Kabiru Tiah Mahama. Hon Member, you have 10 minutes.

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama (NPP — Walewale): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. The Minister for Finance was expected to do a national service on behalf of the President, but rather unfortunately, the Minister failed woefully in representing the President and representing the Republic in this very important assignment.

Before I delve into the Statement by the Minister, this House is a house of records, and it is proper that when statements are made and those statements are not statements of fact, they are fact-checked and the proper facts will have to be put out there for posterity and for the dignity of this House.

The speaker before me, churned out certain data and they think that Ghanaians, as they say, have short memories. Mr Speaker, not all of us have short memories. They talk and claim same and tout their achievements on the performance of the macro-fiscal.

Mr Speaker, I will refer them to history, because they are so fixated on the history and they are not interested in the country moving forward. I will refer them to the history. On the external sector, in 2014, they did a negative trade balance of US\$3.8 billion. In 2014, they did a negative trade balance of US\$1.3 billion. In 2015, they did a negative trade balance of US\$3.1 billion. In 2016, they did a negative trade balance of US\$1.7 billion—Four consecutive years of negative trade deficits.

Today, just in six months, they want us to forget about all these years of hardship, but Mr Speaker, let me again refresh their minds. When we took over in 2017, we did a positive trade balance of US\$1.1 billion. In 2008, we did a positive trade balance of US\$1.8 billion. In 2019, US\$2.2 billion; in 2020, US\$2 billion; and in 2021, US\$1.1 billion. Mr Speaker, those were five consecutive years of trade surplus. Now, they want us to forget about this data because they are just doing some positive macro indicators in the six months. I will come to that.

The speaker also mentioned inflation and said that we did so bad in inflation. Mr Speaker, when we want to measure the strength of the economy, whether the managers of the economy are doing well or they are doing bad, what we need to do

is to find out what the trajectory of the movement of the macro-fiscal is. This Government did not succeed on the back of worsening macroeconomic fiscals. Mr Speaker, every single indicator, inflation, exchange rate, trade surplus, current accounts, primary balance, were all moving in the positive direction when they inherited the Government.

8.12 p.m.

Yet every single one of them, when benchmarked against the 2023 performance, had improved in 2024 and they come to this Chamber and present a picture as if things were deteriorating and they were the Holy Grail and the Messiah sent to save this country. Mr Speaker, that cannot be true; that cannot be the fact and this House will have to correct the record.

Mr Speaker, the Minister for Finance did something so disingenuous and I want to draw the attention of the House to read. On page 23 of his Statement, which is External Sector Performance, this is what he said. He stated that the Gross International Reserve reached US\$11.12 billion by June 2025, covering 4.0 months of import cover, from US\$8.98 billion in December. That is correct, Mr Speaker, but come to paragraph 131. He said the trade surplus increased from US\$1.37 billion in June 2024, but he did not reference December. Why did he not reference December? There is a reason. It is because he wants to hide the US\$1.3 billion recorded in December before we handed over and then he goes to report US\$283 million as surplus. That is the ingenuity of a Minister who has learned

the craft of propaganda to deceive the Ghanaian people.

Mr Speaker, again, I will go ahead to report. Net capital inflow was US\$937.5 billion in June, but again, he failed to report the figure that he inherited in December 2024. This is the dishonesty of the Minister we are talking about. Mr Speaker, I will proceed—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, kindly withdraw the word “dishonesty”.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, that is misleading of the Minister in place of the word dishonesty.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, kindly withdraw.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I withdraw and I say that the act of the Minister is misleading the House. And that for a house of record, we must not entertain a Minister coming to mislead this House with records.

Mr Speaker, we have belaboured and the Government and Minister, again, tried in this Chamber to explain that they are spending. Mr Speaker, if they want to know whether they are spending or not, they should compare this Budget with the 2017 Mid-Year Budget. That is the only way they can understand the point that they are not spending.

Mr Speaker, in the Mid-Year Budget 2017, we programmed to spend an amount of GHC27 billion, but we spent GHC23 billion, which is a difference of

GHC3 billion. Their total expenditure programme was GHC128 billion for half a year. They spent only GHC84 billion, Mr Speaker. They are doing short of about GHC40 billion in total expenditure. And when we say they are not spending, they are trying so hard to explain that they are spending. How can they be spending when they are even failing their own programmed expenditure by some GHC40 billion? Mr Speaker, that is not expenditure.

Mr Speaker, again, they are complaining of *dumsor*, but look at arrears payments in the Energy sector, some GHC2 billion of under-expenditure in the Energy sector has been recorded. No wonder the Minister for Energy and Green Transition will come to this House crying and no wonder that, in the middle of the night, they will increase the Energy Sector Levy Act (ESLA) and ESLA has been reviewed two times in half a year. Mr Speaker, this is what we are talking about. They come to say that they are doing so well and their revenue is not performing. Yet, when we put this before the House, they say we should not talk and that things were bad.

Mr Speaker, the temerity and the audacity of the other people on the other Side to even ask us not to speak is so loud. I will talk about arrears. They told us that they are budgeting some GHC13 billion for arrears. Mr Speaker, when they were reporting how much they have spent on arrears, it is some GHC4.8 billion. For GHC13 billion, they have spent only GHC4.8 billion—[*Interruption*]—We inherited arrears even in your regime, but we paid. I can give you the records for

that. Every single Government we inherited, had arrears of over GHC5 billion in 2017 and we paid. So, do not make it look as if it is only this year that there are arrears to be paid. It is their responsibility to pay for those areas and not to be giving excuses.

Mr Speaker, I will conclude with this: in the first place, the Minister comes to condemn the IMF programme, yet they are enjoying the fruits of the IMF programme. That is —*[Expunged by the order of Mr Speaker]*—misleading, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the word ... be expunged from the record if the Hon Member will not take a cue.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister came to tell us that the Gold Purchase Programme had caused the Bank of Ghana so much pain and so much loss in revenue, yet he says that there was no Gold for Oil Programme. That is misleading.

Mr Speaker, the Minister came to this Chamber to say that there is unemployment, yet he supervised a massive termination of employment. That is misleading. Mr Speaker, he came to tell us that the Domestic Debt Exchange Programme (DDEP) was a painful thing we inflicted on Ghanaians, yet the Minister is cheerfully laughing and happy that they have brought the debt-to-GDP ratio to 46 per cent. That is misleading. Because one cannot blame a Government, on one hand, for causing troubles and on the other hand, enjoy the fruits and laugh

cheerfully and ask us to praise them for same. That is misleading and we should not accept that in this House.

Mr Speaker, lastly, he came to this House to say that we should take solace in the fact that the cedi has destabilised and that they have done so well in stabilising the cedi. But he failed to tell the good people of Ghana that the reserves that we built, which they have reported as eight months of import cover, the Gold Purchase Programme under the Precious Mineral Marketing Company and the IMF loan that came in to support the cedi were all part of the measures we put in place to stabilise the cedi. So, the Minister cannot be telling us that.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion—

Mr Joseph Kwame Kumah (NDC – Kintampo North): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the Motion that this honourable House approves the Mid-Year Review of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the 2025 Financial Year.

Mr Speaker, I am forced to say that if people are referring us to 2014/2015, then I am sad that they are misleading Economics students in this country. Why am I saying so? In this very economy, before the NDC left power, the World Bank then, as of 2014, projected an 8 per cent increase in economic growth. And when my Friends on the other Side threw dust in the eyes of Ghanaians and won power, they said that, within that very year, they made the economy grow by 8 per cent. This year, when we took over from them last year and we are now

talking of better management of the economy, they will say that it is their policies that have brought about the good economic management. What a double standard.

Mr Speaker, in only 202 days today, as we speak, H. E. John Dramani Mahama has not only fulfilled his campaign promises, but has reignited the passion and the love for the educational sector across everywhere. What is happening is that students benefitting from the Free Senior High School (Free SHS), for the first time, are seeing jollof that is reddish, instead of whitish. The students at senior high schools, for the first time, are taking meals with eggs, meat, sardines. I will prove to them with figures. *[Hear! Hear!]*

8.22 p.m.

Mr Speaker, for the first time in eight years, let me tell my Friends on the other Side that Government is not owing any Capitation Grant. *[Hear! Hear!]* Government has paid the whole three years Capitation Grant that is owed by them. My Brothers and Sisters, if they do look at all these things, do they still want to challenge the Government of His Excellency John Dramani Mahama?

If they happened to be my father, they did not manage the house well; they made us owe the road sector not less than GHC120 billion and many other sectors, to the extent that they owed even perishables in senior high schools. The moment their Government left power, the Conference of Heads of Assisted Senior Secondary Schools (CHASS) wrote a long letter to His Excellency John

Dramani Mahama that the previous Government owed them perishables like maggi, common salt and pepper, so they were appealing to His Excellency that if we did not pay those things, then parents should supply gari for their wards who were coming to school.

His Excellency said, no, this cannot happen under his presidency. All the rice in the buffer stocks and any food in any corner should be pushed to the senior high schools and that was when the students started eating jollof with sardine. They jumped all over and thanked His Excellency John Dramani Mahama and till date, senior high schools are benefiting from the best feed ever.

Mr Speaker, if people are making us to know that the Government is exaggerating that we are not spending, I am proving them wrong. I am proving them wrong in the sense that we have uncapped GETFund and for uncapping GETFund—In the previous years, when GETFund was capped, out of the GHC4.8 billion that was accrued, only GHC1.8 could be released to the educational sector. When they capped GETFund, out of the GHC4.8 billion that came in, only 1.8 was available for the educational sector. As we speak, the better Government, the gentle giant, His Excellency John Dramani Mahama, has accrued GHC4.6 billion from GETFund and my Brothers, it has been released fully to GETFund without any pesewa passing anywhere.

Mr Speaker, to continue, an amount of GHC1 billion has been released for Free Senior High and this amount is minus

practical fees that has just been released to pay the West African Examination Council (WAEC) for practicals.

Mr Speaker, in addition, we were in this country not quite long, when WAEC cried on the roofs all over that even moneys for them to pay markers of examinations and service their machines was a problem. While WAEC owed internally, at the same time, they owed externally, under the Regime of Nana Akufo-Addo.

Mr Speaker, additionally, GHC72.8 million for the Capitation Grant has been paid. Let me say, the success story about these payments is that Africa Education Watch (Eduwatch) Ghana has come out with a research on it and has indicated that while the payment for the whole 8 years of the former Administration was 59 per cent because of delays in release of Capitation Grant, the release of this GHC7.2 billion by His Excellency John Dramani Mahama indicates a 100 per cent release. What it means to basic education is that learning activities would be boosted.

Let me indicate on this Floor that Conference of Heads of Basic Schools (COHBS), please, let the fund do the right thing that it has been set up for. The Committee on Education will be coming for monitoring. We do not want to come around and still see broken chairs and windows in basic schools. Please, invest the money the right way.

Mr Speaker, who said the Government of H. E. John Dramani Mahama is not spending? We are

spending. An amount of GH¢122.8 million for Basic Education Certificate Examination (BECE) registration has also been paid. Who said the Government is not spending?

For a government to be able to help its nation, manpower development is very important and that is exactly what this Government is doing. We are not joking. An amount of GH¢300 million has been paid to the No-Fees-Stress Policy. Those who are left are yet to receive the money and that is what this Government is doing. So, if anybody on this Floor does any propaganda that the Government is not spending, no, it is not right.

Mr Speaker, I cannot conclude without mentioning the GH¢191.7 million as teacher training allowances and GH¢62.6 million as nursing training allowances. Students of economics—Ghanaians are listening to us as we debate; we are giving them the figures. They are here; they should go to paragraph 493 of the Budget Statement.

Mr Speaker, I am concluding. Out of the budgeted GH¢499.8 million to the No-Fees-Stress Policy students, we have—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up. It is now the turn of Ms Korkor Asante. You have five minutes.

Ms Laurette Korkor Asante (NPP — Atiwa West): Mr Speaker, Ghanaians across the country were glued to their radios and televisions, hoping that the Mid-Year Budget Review of this year

would finally speak to the real burdens that they wake up to every single day. Soaring utility bills, rising costs of living, the increase and introduction of new taxes, but to their utter dismay, the Hon Minister tiptoed around these pressing concerns as if they did not exist. There is no plan in this Mid-Year Budget Review to cushion the ordinary Ghanaian.

Ghanaians were looking for bold actions. What they got was silence wrapped in spin. This is a Government so insensitive that during the 1st of July, which was a Republic Day, they introduced new taxes, which is a cruel irony commemorating freedom by taxing the people into poverty. We were told that this Government understood the economy and what Ghanaians were going through.

However, they do not understand the suffering of Ghanaians because the Government pledged that they would not impose new taxes. Yet, here we are, a combined 21 per cent tax slapped on non-life insurance, increasing the cost of protecting homes and businesses at a time when citizens are barely surviving.

Electricity tariffs shot up to 14 per cent in May, then two months later, another 2.25 per cent increase, that is like 16 per cent.

8.32p.m.

The cost of locally manufactured plastic products which the local entrepreneurs use for sachet water, for selling *waakye*, for food packaging and other household necessities have increased by 7 per cent. Mr Speaker, how

does this help the ordinary Ghanaian? How does this support local businesses like Koko Boutique who sells *Koko* in Kwabeng, how is this going to help her?

Mr Speaker, when the NDC was in opposition, they said they would reduce taxes and ease burdens but what we are seeing actually is economic betrayal dressed up as economic policy. Mr Speaker, the Government promised a Women's Development Bank as a flagship intervention to support our women. All the women including women in my Constituency at Abomoso, the traders in Kwabeng and the market women in Bunso, all welcomed and were looking forward to this Women's bank. But Mr Speaker, what we heard was that only a paltry GH¢61 million was going to be used as seed money. Even that, we have not heard of anything about this Women's Development Bank. Nothing was mentioned in this budget review for the women's bank. Mr Speaker, to set up a bank in Ghana you need a minimum of GH¢400 million as capital. Mr Speaker, we were told that legal frameworks were being done, preparatory works were underway, but six months down the line, there is no bank, no legal structure, no implementation plan and not even a mention in the Mid-Year Budget. Mr Speaker where is the Women's Development Bank? Where is the Women's Development Bank? *Anaa killer antua enti President Mahama nso entua anaa?* This so-called Women's Development Bank has become a ghost, budgeted in hoop and buried in silence. A government in action speaks louder than what they are doing. Clearly, Mr Speaker the government is unable to deliver or

they just do not have the will. Mr Speaker the Women's Development Bank is *yaamutu*.

Mr Speaker it is deeply alarming as well that the government has discontinued impactful programmes like the YouStart Initiative and the 1D1F Programme. Mr Speaker, the 1D1F was aimed at decentralising industrialisation and creating rural jobs. They have removed that and till now they have not replaced it with any viable programme. Mr Speaker, those programmes were not just slogans. They were supposed to be providing jobs for the youth in rural towns like my town in Abomosu.

[Hear! Hear!]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have exhausted the list of debaters for today. We shall defer the debate till tomorrow. We shall continue it.

We now turn to Order Paper Addendum, the item numbered 3.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker we have done a lot. We are exhausted. Mr Speaker look at the Chamber, we are in your hands for adjournment. Mr Speaker, I have related with my Colleague and we have engaged on that Business and we said that would be the first item we will take tomorrow. Mr Speaker, look at the Chamber and I do not want it to—we have had a very fruitful engagement today. I do not want us to end on a different note.

So, with respect I have reached out to Hon Acheampong that we should do the

Business—and I have engaged the Minister too that we should do the Business tomorrow.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, indeed we talked to each other about it but I was still pleading with him to allow us take the Report so that we continue tomorrow looking at the time. Let us take the Report; one from each Side. So that we will do the consideration tomorrow. I am just pleading with you.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I know you always guide us. Mr Speaker, we have done a lot today and we have been able to go through the things that we agreed on at Conclave. So with respect, I am just appealing to my Colleague Hon Acheampong, the Second Deputy Majority Whip and the Minister responsible for Gender, Children and Social Protection that her Business will be prioritised so that we can do it tomorrow. I do not want us to end on a different note. So, I beg you. With respect, let us do it tomorrow.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, if my Colleague will give us the assurance that— tomorrow, the Minister will be engaged somewhere and it will be difficult to get the Minister to be with us. And I do not want a situation whereby we will come to the item and they will raise the issue that the Minister is not here. So, if only he can give me that assurance.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, there is no problem. Tomorrow, we can

do it and if you even observe very well, we would only need the Minister for the Third Reading and nothing more. Everything that we are doing—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member we need the Minister for Second Reading.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Yes Mr Speaker, we do not have a problem if the Minister would not be available. That should not be a problem. We have done that with several Ministers not being here. So, we have had that arrangement during our engagement already. But the Minister says that she will be here; that is what she told me. She told me she will be here.

Mr Acheampong: Hon Habib, with this back and forth, if we allowed ourselves to take the Report, we would have even finished taking the Report. Too much talking is not good for our health.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, we are taking adjournment until 2 o'clock tomorrow.

[Pause]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, what is the pleasure of the House?

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker I am still pleading with my Colleagues for us to take their Report for just five minutes so that we act on this please. Hon Habib, you know there is a limit for endurance.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, the pleasure of the House is that let us take an adjournment. Mr Speaker, if you want to take the Report for which the House needs to take a decision— Mr Speaker, I do not want to go in that direction. We cannot satisfy the constitutional requirement under Article 104.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this House is accordingly adjourned until Tuesday, 29th July, 2025 at 2:00 in the afternoon.

Thank you.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was adjourned at 8.42 p.m. till Tuesday, 29th July, 2025 at 2:00 p.m.

